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"AI Will Not Replace Journalists, but a Journalist Who Uses AI Will": AI Integration and the Changing Boundaries of Journalistic Work in Public Service Media

Student: Joel Olai

Supervisor: Peter Jakobsson

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Abstract

This study examines how AI is integrated into journalistic work within Swedish Public Service Media (PSM), focusing on how journalists and key organisational actors at Sveriges Radio experience and negotiate the growing presence of AI in newsroom practice. The study investigates how AI tools are incorporated into journalistic workflows, how journalists understand and negotiate the role and boundaries of AI use in relation to their perceptions of journalistic and PSM values, and how they describe the opportunities, challenges and educational needs associated with increasing AI integration. The study draws on the Structurational Model of Technology, Institutional Theory and perspectives on Public Service Media Legitimacy in order to analyse how AI is negotiated and legitimised within an institutional journalistic context. Methodologically, it uses a qualitative case study design based on semi-structured interviews with journalists, an editor-in-chief and an AI strategist at Sveriges Radio, with the empirical material analysed through thematic analysis.

The findings suggest that AI is primarily legitimised when supporting routine and time-consuming tasks such as transcription, translation, summarisation, research and data processing, allowing journalists to focus more on editorial judgement and creative work. AI is also perceived as expanding journalistic practice by enabling new forms of analysis and problem-solving. However, it becomes contested when approaching tasks linked to authorship, accountability, creativity and human interaction. The study shows that AI integration generates tensions around competence, skill development, organisational expectations and journalistic identity, particularly within PSM, where legitimacy is tied to trust, transparency, editorial independence and democratic responsibility. It contributes to research on AI in journalism by framing adoption as an ongoing sociotechnical, institutional and professional negotiation, highlighting the need for situated AI literacy, continuous learning and critical human oversight.

Keywords: Artificial Intelligence, Journalism, Public Service Media, AI in Journalism, Institutional Theory, Newsroom Practices, AI Literacy, Sveriges Radio

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1. Introduction

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is not the first technology to transform journalism, but it may be one of the most contested. Historically, journalism has been characterised by continuous technological innovation, as news organisations broadly can be understood as institutions that produce news content and distribute it to audiences through technological means (Wadbring & Karlsson, 2024, pp. 51–56). Positioned among the latest technological advancements, AI is argued to have spread across journalistic practice in ways that set it apart from earlier forms of technological change (Dodds et al., 2026, p. 532). AI has been shown to streamline journalistic workflows by accelerating production, supporting new ideas and enabling large-scale data handling (Calvo-Rubio & Rojas-Torrijos, 2024). In only a few years, AI in journalism has developed into a rapidly evolving field, where newsroom practices and professional norms surrounding its use are still taking shape (Ioscote et al., 2024).

The contemporary media environment is marked by declining advertising revenues, shifting audience habits and intensified digital competition. As a result, many news organisations are increasingly adopting AI technologies in an effort to remain competitive and respond to structural changes within the industry (Simon, 2024). However, the idea that journalism must simply adapt to technological change can be problematised. Örnebring (2010) argues that journalism has often treated technology as an external and inevitable force, rather than as something whose use and meaning can be actively shaped by journalistic values. This is closely connected to journalism's long-standing emphasis on efficiency, where ideals of immediacy and technological progress have shaped both news production and distribution.

While the potential of AI is frequently emphasised, its implementation also raises broader questions about accuracy, accountability, editorial responsibility and trust. This is illustrated in one of the largest cross-market studies conducted by the BBC and the EBU, which identified substantial shortcomings in how generative AI assistants handle and present journalistic information (British Broadcasting Corporation & European Broadcasting Union, 2025). The report found that nearly half of the AI-generated news responses contained significant inaccuracies related to sourcing, factual errors, insufficient context and the misrepresentation of quotes. AI assistants were also found to present outdated or misleading information while communicating in a confident and authoritative tone, despite lacking the transparency and verification standards associated with professional journalism. One of the

report's overarching conclusions is that AI assistants are still not dependable means of accessing news content.

Audience research also shows that attitudes toward AI in journalism remain cautious and sceptical (Simon et al., 2025). Audiences clearly distinguish between AI-produced and human-produced journalism, with many viewing increased AI involvement in news production as a potential threat to news quality and trustworthiness. This creates a central challenge for journalism: how can AI be implemented responsibly in a context where the technology is associated with inaccuracy and where audiences remain sceptical of its role in news production?

This becomes particularly significant within a public service media (PSM) context, where legitimacy depends heavily on sustaining public trust and a credible journalistic mission. Technological change in PSM is shaped by institutional conditions that distinguish it from commercial media. Public funding, legal mandates and democratic obligations require PSM organisations to continuously justify their societal relevance and public value (Koivula et al., 2022; Olsen et al., 2025; Fieiras-Ceide et al., 2024; Lischka, 2025). Consequently, AI adoption in PSM extends beyond technical and organisational considerations to questions of how the technology aligns with public service values and journalistic responsibility.

While previous research has examined AI implementation in journalism in relation to organisational strategy, technological infrastructure and professional governance, less attention has been paid to how journalists themselves understand and negotiate AI, particularly within a PSM context. This makes the Swedish case notably relevant, as AI integration takes place within a media system characterised by strong public service institutions, high levels of trust in news media and long-standing traditions of editorial independence (Lindell et al., 2022). By examining how Swedish PSM journalists understand and negotiate AI in their everyday work, this study contributes to knowledge about how emerging technologies are interpreted within journalism under conditions of public responsibility and democratic accountability.

1.1 Aim and Research Questions

The aim of this study is to examine how AI tools are integrated into journalistic work within Swedish PSM, by exploring how journalists at Sveriges Radio experience and navigate the growing presence of AI in newsroom practice. The study seeks to contribute to a deeper

understanding of how AI influences everyday work processes, and how journalists make sense of the technology in relation to their perceptions of journalistic norms and public service values. Furthermore, it examines how the implementation of AI gives rise to new challenges, uncertainties and demands for competence development within the newsroom. The following research questions are explored through journalists' own experiences and perspectives:

- **RQ1:** How are AI tools integrated into journalistic workflows, and how do journalists describe changes in their everyday work practices?
- **RQ2:** How do journalists understand and negotiate the role and boundaries of AI use in relation to their perceptions of journalistic and public service values?
- **RQ3:** How do journalists describe the opportunities, challenges and educational needs associated with the increasing integration of AI in journalistic work?

1.2 Structure

The following background section provides the contextual foundation for the study by situating AI within the broader development of journalism and by outlining how AI has been introduced and governed at Sveriges Radio. The previous research chapter then reviews existing literature on AI implementation in news organisations, journalistic norms in relation to AI and technological change in PSM, before identifying the research gaps addressed by the study. The theory chapter presents the theoretical framework, consisting of the Structurational Model of Technology, Institutional Theory and perspectives on Public Service Media Legitimacy, which together guide the analysis. The methodology chapter outlines the qualitative research design, data collection, sampling, semi-structured interviews, analytical process and methodological considerations. The results chapter presents the empirical findings, focusing on journalists' use of AI, their interpretations and attitudes toward the technology and the tensions connected to learning and integrating AI in journalistic work. Finally, the conclusion and discussion chapter relates the findings to previous research and theory, reflects on the study's limitations and ethical implications and concludes by suggesting areas for future research. The thesis ends with a reference list.

1.3 Background

This section provides the contextual foundation for the study by first situating AI within the broader development of journalism, before turning to how these changes are reflected in the specific case of Sveriges Radio. Together, it clarifies the technological and organisational background against which the study's empirical analysis should be understood.

1.3.1 Evolution of AI in Journalism

Interest in the topic has expanded significantly in recent years as "AI has increasingly reshaped the field of journalism" (Cervi et al., 2026, p. 48). Key areas of research include the integration of AI technologies in newsrooms, changes in news production, consumption and the emergence of new media business models (Sonni, 2025). AI is portrayed as an increasingly integrated part of journalism, while simultaneously raising concerns regarding regulation, transparency and the need for improved AI literacy among journalists (Feio & Oliveira, 2025).

AI integration in journalism has developed through several distinct stages. Early applications emerging around 2010 primarily focused on automated text generation for structured topics such as finance, sports, and weather, relying on predefined templates that improved efficiency while limiting creative capacity (Ioscote et al., 2024). A significant shift occurred with the emergence of generative AI in 2022, particularly through large language models trained on vast amounts of text data to identify patterns and generate contextually coherent responses (de-Lima-Santos et al., 2025; Ioscote et al., 2024). The public release of systems such as ChatGPT accelerated AI's expansion across the entire news chain, where it went from information gathering and content production to distribution and audience engagement (Pavlik, 2023, p. 85). Generative AI enables automation of routine tasks, reduces production time, supports idea generation and enables large-scale data analysis, thereby streamlining workflows and enhancing efficiency (Calvo-Rubio & Rojas-Torrijos, 2024; Cools & Diakopoulos, 2024). It has changed journalistic practice, influencing professional roles, required competencies and the understanding of editorial responsibility (Calvo-Rubio & Rojas-Torrijos, 2024, p. 250). Unlike earlier analytical systems that processed structured data within predefined templates, generative AI can generate text, images and audio from unstructured data, producing contextually coherent outputs that simulate autonomous reasoning rather than merely analysing inputs (Ioscote et al., 2024, p. 875).

However, it remains necessary to critically question whether generative AI constitutes the disruptive transformation of journalism that much of the literature suggests. Dodds et al. (2026) argue that generative AI may represent a critical turning point for journalism because it affects the foundations of how news is produced, understood and defined. They describe AI as "unusually wide-ranging (across industries), pervasive (across aspects of newswork), and fundamental (challenging traditional divisions between humans and computers)" (p. 532). From this perspective, AI differs from earlier technological developments because it spreads rapidly across multiple areas of journalistic work and increasingly blurs the boundary between human and machine-generated content.

This disruptive interpretation of AI can be questioned through Deuze and Witschge's (2018) argument that journalism should not be treated as a stable institution periodically shaken by singular technological breakthroughs. They instead conceptualise journalism as a dynamic and continuously evolving field, shaped by shifting technological, organisational and cultural conditions. This perspective makes it possible to view generative AI less as a distinct rupture with the past and more as part of journalism's ongoing negotiation with technological change. This becomes particularly relevant when AI is placed in relation to earlier waves of automation in journalism. News organisations have already adapted to digitalisation, algorithmic journalism and automated news writing (Dörr, 2016; Graefe, 2016). Generative AI may therefore represent an intensification of existing developments rather than an entirely new departure. Its significance lies in the scale and speed with which automation now enters journalistic work, but its emergence still belongs to a longer history of technological innovation within the news industry.

1.3.2 Swedish PSM and AI at Sveriges Radio

Swedish PSM consists of Sveriges Radio (SR), Sveriges Television (SVT) and Sveriges Utbildningsradio (UR), which are funded through the public service fee. Sveriges Radio is Sweden's national public service radio broadcaster and describes its mission as providing journalism that is independent of political, religious, commercial and other interests (Sveriges Radio, 2026a). At the same time, Swedish PSM operates within a broader political context where its role, funding and future direction are regularly debated. These questions have been particularly visible in discussions about the public service framework for 2026-2033 (Regeringskansliet, 2025), including concerns that future funding may not be sufficient to cover rising costs, potentially requiring significant cuts at Sveriges Radio (Dahlin, 2025).

This context is relevant for the study because it shows that AI adoption at Sveriges Radio takes place in an environment where technological change must be understood in relation to the organisation's public service mission and its need to maintain confidence as an independent journalistic institution.

Within a context characterised by both institutional expectations and resource pressures, Sveriges Radio's 2023 policy on generative AI reflects the organisation's interest in exploring how new technologies can support journalistic work (Sveriges Radio, 2023). The policy presents AI as a tool for improving efficiency while strengthening the organisation's offering to audiences. By 2023, AI had already been used for several years in areas such as podcast recommendations and news curation. However, the emergence of increasingly powerful generative AI models marked a significant shift, as these technologies began to be used both through external services and, increasingly, through systems integrated into everyday news production.

Further, as the use of AI in journalism continued to expand, strong emphasis was placed on the importance of responsible AI use, particularly the need for transparency regarding how and for what purposes AI tools are applied. This led to the launch of an internally developed AI system in October 2025 (Sveriges Radio, 2025). The organisation introduced an AI portal containing educational material that employees are expected to complete, alongside the launch of an internally developed AI tool called Prompto. The internal AI tool was developed to ensure control, editorial independence, and secure in-house data handling. Its purpose is to provide employees with a secure environment in which they can use advanced language models and analyse and summarise documents safely, alongside training in risk awareness and responsible journalistic AI use. Following its launch, additional training initiatives were introduced to build on previous educational efforts, focusing on risk awareness, AI competence, and practical workshops with AI coaches aimed at helping employees use AI in a safe and responsible manner to strengthen journalistic work.

In 2026, Sveriges Radio announced that it would not use synthetic AI voices. Sveriges Radio justified this decision by arguing that "in a time when technology is advancing rapidly, it is crucial not to lose sight of what actually creates trust", and that "while many see AI redrawing the entire media landscape, our most important task remains the same: to maintain trust in our content regardless of technological change" (Sveriges Radio, 2026b).

2. Previous Research

This chapter reviews existing research related to AI and journalism. It begins by examining how AI is implemented in news organisations and how it relates to journalistic norms. The chapter then discusses technological change in PSM and concludes with an overview of the research field and the gaps.

2.1 AI Implementation in News Organisations

News organisations adopt AI for several interrelated reasons. Drawing on interviews with news workers and experts in the United States, the United Kingdom, and Germany, Simon (2024, pp. 11–13) identified four primary motivations: technological advancements, market pressures, industry trends and organisational considerations. The recognition of technological progress, along with easy access to AI tools and their rapid adoption in other industries, as well as by competitors, has driven news organisations to implement AI technologies. Facing market pressures from outdated business models, media executives are eager to improve efficiency and cut costs, while industry hype and high expectations further encourage experimentation and innovation. This is consistent with broader research suggesting that AI is increasingly integrated into long-term organisational strategies designed to increase productivity, support innovation and maintain competitiveness in a rapidly evolving digital media environment (Calvo-Rubio & Rojas-Torrijos, 2024; Ioscote et al., 2024).

Lischka (2025) argues that AI implementation is further influenced by broader structural conditions, such as a country's innovation environment. Countries that possess well-developed innovation systems, including supportive AI governance, strong technological foundations and robust economies, are significantly more likely to foster technological innovation. Similarly, Kunert and von Nordheim (2025) argue that the successful implementation of AI depends less on the technology itself and more on the organisational environment surrounding it, drawing on observations and interviews with members of an innovation hub at the German public service broadcaster Westdeutscher Rundfunk (WDR). Thus, AI innovation is argued to likely thrive when organisations cultivate strategic intent, collaborative structures and a culture of experimental learning.

Regarding the development of AI systems, research shows that news organisations differ in how they balance internal and external solutions. Some organisations implement AI through a

combination of externally provided platforms, licensed tools and internally developed systems, often supported by dedicated innovation labs or development hubs (Fieiras-Ceide et al., 2024; Jones et al., 2022; Kunert & von Nordheim, 2025). However, studies suggest that most news organisations remain largely dependent on the infrastructure and services provided by major technology companies (Simon, 2024). Due to the high costs associated with computing power and specialised expertise, independent AI development is often beyond the reach of many newsrooms. Therefore, news organisations frequently rely on tools and infrastructure from large technology providers rather than building their own AI systems (Simon, 2024).

A central theme regarding AI tools and their development is the call from both journalists and media organisations for responsible AI use (Jones et al., 2022; de-Lima-Santos et al., 2025). In some cases, this reflects journalists' desire for greater AI literacy, emphasising critical understanding and accountability over purely technical training (Couraceiro et al., 2025; Jones et al., 2022). Cools and Diakopoulos (2024) show that journalists emphasise the need for human oversight, transparency in AI use and clear communication from management in order to establish trust with audiences and provide guidance for journalists. Research indicates that journalists are wary of opaque AI systems whose decision-making processes are not transparent, as well as the increasing reliance on tools from major technology companies (Jones et al., 2022; Kunert & von Nordheim, 2025). Simon (2024) further finds that journalists and news organisations are worried that AI systems obscure how decisions are made, which can restrict professional autonomy, embed bias and influence what is deemed newsworthy. In addition, Simon (2024) points out that beyond individual concerns, organisations also fear that growing reliance on tech companies reduces control over both content creation and audience reach, threatening editorial independence and sustainable business models.

These concerns regarding opacity of AI systems, biases and increasing platform dependence have prompted many news organisations to introduce formal AI guidelines. However, research indicates that such policies are often perceived as general and underspecified, offering limited practical direction for how AI should be applied across different stages of news production (de-Lima-Santos et al., 2025). As a result, these guidelines risk serving more as symbolic policy statements or expressions of values than as practical guidance for journalists working with AI. Cools and Diakopoulos (2024) show that when clear guidelines

are lacking regarding which AI tools can be used and how, journalists express concern about careless or unsafe AI use, including the risk of reinforcing existing biases and discriminatory patterns from opaque AI systems. Their study found that the absence of clear communication and policies from management regarding generative AI created uncertainty among journalists, even as many had already begun using these tools. This raised concerns about unregulated AI use, which could amplify bias and pose ethical and professional risks.

2.2 Journalistic Norms in Relation to AI

Beyond newsroom strategies, organisational environments and technological capabilities, AI implementation is also shaped by journalistic norms (Lischka, 2025). While these norms can reinforce ethical and professional standards, they may also constrain experimentation and innovation. Ioscote et al. (2024) highlight the tension between traditional journalistic principles, such as credibility, accuracy and nuanced reporting, with the use of AI in news production. Simon (2024) further notes that, although AI can assist journalistic work, its use is limited by the requirement to uphold core professional norms. Journalists report that AI tools can help with tasks such as summarisation, transcription or drafting, but the outputs can be unreliable. This often requires additional verification and may, in some cases, be more time-consuming than completing the work manually. Similarly, Cools and Diakopoulos (2024) note that journalists approach generative AI cautiously, viewing it as prone to poor editorial judgement, oversimplifying complex issues and producing biased or inaccurate information, which makes careful fact-checking essential to preserve accuracy and maintain credibility.

However, on certain topics with a lot of statistical data, such as sports, automated news has been well received by audiences, who often perceive it as more objective due to its reliance on numbers (Ioscote et al., 2024). Despite this, Calvo-Rubio and Rojas-Torrijos (2024) emphasise that most journalists see AI as having clear limitations and believe it cannot replace humans for all types of reporting. They note that AI is particularly constrained in interpretative or narrative journalism, where journalists often see it struggling to capture nuance, emotion and the stylistic depth that skilled journalists bring to their work. Similarly, Cools and Diakopoulos (2024) find that journalists fear AI could undermine their personal voice and autonomy. They emphasise that the human touch remains essential for emotional depth, audience engagement, creativity and original reporting. Over-reliance on AI, they

argue, risks homogenising content and reducing critical engagement. Hilker et al. (2025) extends this perspective of resistance to AI by showing that normative pressures often generate resistance to change.

However, Lischka (2025) argues that although journalistic innovation is often shaped by established professional norms, these norms are not static and may evolve as AI advancements become validated and institutionalised. An example she takes is through recognition from prestigious awards, where AI appears more likely to enhance rather than undermine traditional journalistic practices over time. This perspective challenges techno-deterministic concerns that AI will supplant human judgement, suggesting instead that professional discretion can continue to shape the way new technologies are adopted and integrated.

2.3 Public Service Media and Technological Change

Across studies, innovation in publicly funded media is consistently described as both necessary and constrained. While PSM are often portrayed as having relatively stable resources for research and development, innovation is frequently characterised as incremental and risk-averse, shaped by journalistic routines, political scrutiny and expectations of responsible use of public funds (Koivula et al., 2022; Kunert & von Nordheim, 2025). To balance renewal and stability, innovation is often contained through experimentation without disrupting core editorial work (Koivula et al., 2022; Kunert & von Nordheim, 2025).

Further, AI is described as a technology that PSM governance seeks to reconcile with public service mandates and societal trust, resulting in innovation processes that are portrayed in the literature as particularly transparent and institutionally embedded (Jones et al., 2022; Hilker et al., 2025). Growing dependence on external platforms and infrastructures creates structural tensions within PSM. This dependence can limit editorial control, as algorithmic governance and data practices largely remain outside the oversight of PSM institutions (Olsen et al., 2025; Simon, 2024).

2.4 Overview of Research and Gaps

Research shows that AI is rapidly transforming journalism, from early automated reporting to advanced generative systems that impact workflows, professional roles and editorial practices. News organisations adopt AI to improve efficiency and remain competitive, but

implementation depends heavily on organisational culture and resources. Journalists face tensions between AI use and traditional norms, balancing innovation with accuracy and human judgement. In PSM, innovation is cautious and institutionally embedded, highlighting the need for clear guidelines and improved AI literacy. Despite growing research, key gaps remain. Research indicates that there is still limited knowledge about how AI is adopted in newsrooms, how it affects journalistic practices and what organisational and ethical implications follow from its use (García-Avilés, 2021). There is also a need for further understanding of how AI affects journalistic roles and professional identities, as well as a need for stronger ethical frameworks and for understanding how AI can be integrated in ways that complement rather than replace human judgement (Sonni et al., 2024; Sonni, 2025).

Against this backdrop, the present study contributes to further understanding of AI integration in journalism by examining how it is experienced and interpreted within a specific PSM newsroom. Focusing on a newsroom at Sveriges Radio, the study explores how journalists and key organisational actors make sense of AI in relation to editorial responsibility and their perceptions of journalistic and public service values. It also considers how questions of competence and professional adaptation are negotiated as AI becomes an increasingly present part of journalistic work.

3. Theory

This study draws on the Structurational Model of Technology, Institutional Theory, and the concept of Public Service Media Legitimacy. In the following sections, each perspective is introduced and its analytical relevance outlined, before their combined application is presented as an integrated framework for examining how AI is adopted, interpreted, negotiated and legitimised within Sveriges Radio.

3.1 Structurational Model of Technology

The Structurational Model of Technology is a theoretical model designed to understand how technology and organisations shape each other through ongoing interaction (Orlikowski, 1992). Grounded in Anthony Giddens' structuration theory (1984), which views social structures as both shaping and being reproduced through human action, the structurational model of technology, developed by Wanda Orlikowski, understands technology as both created by people and influencing how people work and organise (Orlikowski, 1992, p. 404).

The model responds to earlier debates within technology research, viewing technology either as a determining force that shapes organisations, *or* as something entirely shaped by human interpretation (Orlikowski, 1992, pp. 399–403). Instead, Orlikowski argues that technology should be seen as both socially enacted and structurally influential, captured through the concepts of *duality of technology* and *interpretive flexibility of technology* (Orlikowski, 1992, pp. 406–408).

The concept of the duality of technology describes the two-way relationship between humans and technology. Technologies are created by people, but once they are introduced into an organisation, they also begin to further shape how people work, communicate and organise their activities (Orlikowski, 1992, p. 406). In other words, designers influence how a technology is built, including why and when it should be used. At the same time, the technology can be argued to reshape human practices. For example, editors may begin to expect faster production, workflows may change and journalists may become increasingly reliant on automated systems rather than traditional journalistic skills. The technology itself can make some actions easier and others more difficult, thereby influencing work routines and decision-making. Over time, technologies may become so embedded in organisational

practice that they appear natural or fixed, even though they remain the result of human choices, interpretations and organisational decisions.

The second concept, interpretive flexibility, suggests that the impact of technology depends on how people interact with and use it. These interactions are shaped by the technology itself, users' knowledge and motivations, as well as the rules and culture of the organisation (Orlikowski, 1992, pp. 407, 408). Interpretive flexibility therefore helps explain why similar technologies may support collaboration in one setting, create resistance in another, or be adapted in unexpected ways by users. At the same time, the concept does imply that users' interpretations are shaped by organisational structures, power relations and the technical limits of the system.

3.2 Institutional Theory

Institutional Theory explains how social order is created and maintained through enduring systems of rules, norms and shared meanings (Scott, 2014). Institutions guide behaviour by defining what is perceived as normal, legitimate and acceptable, while both constraining and enabling action through rules, values, routines and resources (Scott, 2014, pp. 56–59). Although institutions are relatively resistant to change, they are not static, but evolve through processes of institutionalisation and deinstitutionalisation (Scott, 2014, p. 58).

According to Scott (2014), institutions are supported by three pillars that shape behaviour in different ways and help define what is considered legitimate, appropriate and taken for granted within a particular context. *The regulatory pillar* emphasises rules, monitoring and sanctions (Scott, 2014, pp. 59–64), while *the normative pillar* focuses on norms, roles and obligations that define appropriate goals and behaviour (Scott, 2014, pp. 64–66). *The cultural-cognitive pillar* highlights taken-for-granted beliefs and shared meaning systems that shape how actors interpret reality (Scott, 2014, pp. 66–70). These pillars operate through different mechanisms, but their relative importance varies across institutional contexts (Scott, 2014, pp. 70–71). In some settings, one pillar may be especially visible, while in others all three reinforce one another and create more stable and legitimate social structures.

Institutions can therefore be understood as the rule-based, normative and cultural environments within which organisations operate. These environments establish the boundaries of legitimate and appropriate action, while organisations adapt their practices in relation to the expectations of the field (Scott, 2014). In journalism, professional values such

as objectivity, impartiality, transparency and responsibility, form an important ethical foundation (de-Lima-Santos et al., 2025, pp. 2588–2590). These values are formalised through codes of ethics and professional guidelines, but they are also continuously interpreted and negotiated within organisations. At the same time, they define the boundaries of journalism by distinguishing acceptable practices from deviant ones, thereby contributing to the credibility and integrity of the field. Institutional theory highlights how such norms are reinforced by both internal professional cultures and external pressures, including regulatory expectations, cultural beliefs and broader media system structures (de-Lima-Santos et al., 2025, pp. 2588–2590).

Organisations further seek legitimacy and stability by aligning with institutionalised expectations (Scott, 2014, p. 71). In media organisations, this may lead to the adoption of similar structures, procedures and standards over time, a process described as *institutional isomorphism* (de-Lima-Santos et al., 2025, p. 2589). When new technologies are introduced, they therefore enter professional environments already shaped by established norms and standards. These norms function both as external frameworks and as internalised professional expectations among journalists, shaping how technological innovations are understood and either accepted or resisted.

Within these normative structures, journalists' individual professional identities are embedded, also shaping how they navigate technological change. Professional identity is argued to develop through the interaction of personal vocation, organisational work and the broader institutional ideology of journalism (Raemy, 2021). *Vocation* reflects individual motivation and commitment to the profession, *organisational work* encompasses the concrete tasks and responsibilities of newsroom practice and *institutional ideology* represents the overarching norms, values and societal mission guiding journalism (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849). As journalists navigate organisational demands and institutional expectations, their professional identity is continuously constructed and renegotiated.

Technological innovation is therefore filtered through established institutional and professional frameworks. If new tools are perceived as challenging core journalistic values, professional identity or accepted standards of practice, they are likely to generate scepticism or resistance. Conversely, when innovations can be interpreted as consistent with prevailing norms, regulatory expectations and journalism's societal mission, they are more likely to gain legitimacy and become integrated into routine practice. In the context of Sveriges Radio, this

enables an analysis of AI adoption as a process through which new tools must be interpreted, justified and made legitimate within existing journalistic norms and professional ideals.

3.3 Public Service Media Legitimacy

To further contextualise AI adoption within PSM, this study integrates the concept of Public Service Media Legitimacy (Puppis & Ali, 2023), situating PSM within debates about democratic legitimacy and societal contribution.

Puppis and Ali (2023, pp. 9–28) argue that contemporary debates about PSM are fundamentally about legitimacy. In a digital and increasingly neoliberal media environment, PSM are required to justify their existence politically, but also economically and socially. The European Broadcasting Union's concept of "contribution to society" was introduced as a way for PSM to demonstrate their value to citizens, policymakers, and market actors (Puppis & Ali, 2023, p. 10). However, it is argued that this concept risks becoming a strategic communication tool focused on defending institutional survival rather than addressing deeper structural and democratic questions. They argue that legitimacy cannot be secured merely through improved communication or efficiency-based arguments (Puppis & Ali, 2023, p. 19). Instead, PSM must articulate and enact a societal role that goes beyond market logic, emphasising democratic participation, cultural inclusion and public interest. This argument is highly relevant for analysing AI adoption. AI is often justified through discourses of efficiency, innovation, competitiveness and modernisation (Simon, 2022, p. 1834). Yet, for PSM, it is argued that legitimacy cannot rest solely on technological advancement or economic rationality (Puppis & Ali, 2023, p. 21). AI must be evaluated in relation to whether it strengthens or weakens PSM's democratic contribution. In this sense, technological innovation becomes embedded in a broader normative struggle over how PSM define their societal mission.

The concept of legitimacy is further developed by the distinction between legitimacy as a property, as a strategic process and as perception (Fehlmann, 2023, pp. 31–46). Fehlmann (2023, p. 42) argues that legitimacy extends beyond organisational management and strategic communication. It is also shaped by how citizens evaluate PSM through their own norms and values. From this perspective, legitimacy emerges through public recognition and social approval rather than through performance indicators alone. While the present study does not investigate audience perceptions empirically, legitimacy remains analytically relevant

because journalists' understandings of AI are partly shaped by their assumptions about how audiences may interpret its use. Thus, public trust can be examined through audience response and as a perceived condition shaping how journalists evaluate the appropriateness and limits of AI in public service journalism. From this perspective, legitimacy emerges through journalists' interpretations of audience expectations, linking institutional norms to the practical negotiation of AI's role in journalism.

This perspective underscores that PSM function within an institutional environment where legitimacy is constantly at stake. In this setting, the introduction of AI also carries normative and political implications. The deployment of AI must therefore be assessed in relation to core public service principles such as independence, universality, transparency and democratic responsibility. When AI applications are perceived as threatening to these principles, they may erode institutional legitimacy.

3.4 Synthesis of the Theoretical Perspectives

Combined, these theoretical perspectives enable a comprehensive analysis of how AI is used in public service journalism and how its use becomes connected to workflows and professional norms. The Structurational Model of Technology serves as the overarching analytical lens, framing AI as a sociotechnical system whose meaning and effects emerge through the interaction between journalists, technologies and organisational routines. Within this framework, the duality of technology and interpretive flexibility highlight how journalists actively interpret, adapt and appropriate AI tools in their daily work, while these technologies may also influence newsroom practices and professional roles. These interactions could be seen as embedded within institutional contexts characterised by established journalistic norms, professional values and organisational expectations. Journalistic norms and professional values can be understood as shaping how journalists assess the reliability and suitability of AI, as well as their expectations around transparency and accountability. From this perspective, institutional dynamics influence how AI is interpreted and how its use gradually becomes established over time. Furthermore, in the context of Sveriges Radio, these dynamics are situated within a broader societal framework. Given the democratic mission of PSM, the adoption and use of AI could be argued to be continuously assessed in relation to public service values and the need to maintain public trust. This highlights how questions of legitimacy and societal responsibility are closely intertwined with everyday technological practices.

4. Methodology

This chapter outlines the methodological approach used in the study. It presents the research design, data collection process, including sampling and semi-structured interviews, and the analytical approach used to examine the data. The chapter also discusses methodological considerations, including ethical issues, credibility and the limitations of the study.

4.1 Research Design

The study employs a qualitative research design, using semi-structured interviews with journalists, a newsroom editor-in-chief and an AI strategist at Sveriges Radio. Qualitative research is used to generate an in-depth understanding of social phenomena by examining how individuals, groups and organisations experience, interpret and act within different contexts (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 426). As this study examines how AI is used in journalistic work and how journalists relate to the technology within a PSM context, a qualitative approach is well suited, as it focuses on the interviewees' experiences and perspectives. As previous research shows that AI in journalism is a rapidly developing field, newsroom practices, norms and organisational strategies surrounding its use are still evolving (Ioscote et al., 2024). This makes journalists' perspectives particularly relevant, as their experiences can provide insight into how AI is interpreted and incorporated before its role in journalistic work has become fully established. Examining these perspectives therefore makes it possible to understand how AI is negotiated in practice, including how journalists define appropriate use and relate the technology to professional values.

Semi-structured interviews were selected as the data collection method since the study aims to capture participants' perceptions and interpretations of events and processes they have experienced. The method allows for rich and detailed responses (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 519), making it particularly suitable for examining journalists' opinions and perceptions in depth. This approach allows the study to explore how interviewees explain and make sense of practices and developments, while also providing flexibility in the interview process (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 519). During the interviews, an interview guide was used, containing questions related to the broader themes of the study. The interview guide included open-ended questions and allowed for follow-up questions, providing flexibility to explore unexpected themes while capturing participants' own experiences and perspectives (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 519). At the same time, using the same interview guide across all interviews provided a

degree of comparability between participants' responses, which supported the subsequent analysis and interpretation of recurring patterns. As the method captures the studied context through participants' own perspectives (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 431), it allows this study to gain deeper insights into newsroom work processes and organisational conditions that are often difficult to observe externally.

The collected data are analysed using thematic analysis, a method designed to systematically identify and examine recurring patterns of meaning, or themes, within a dataset (Braun & Clarke, 2012). A theme can be understood as a category that emerges through the coding process and captures patterns in the data that are relevant to the study's focus and research questions. In this way, themes provide a basis for developing a deeper theoretical understanding of the material (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 657). The coding process can be outlined in six steps: familiarising with the data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing and refining them, defining and naming them and producing the final report (Braun & Clarke, 2012). Initially, interesting points and impressions were noted. Relevant features were then systematically coded and related codes were subsequently grouped into potential themes. These themes were then reviewed for coherence, refined to capture their core meaning, clearly defined and ultimately integrated into a cohesive report that interprets the patterns in relation to the research questions.

4.2 Data Collection

The data collection process was designed to capture perspectives from both journalistic practice and organisational leadership regarding the implementation and use of AI in the newsroom. The following sections describe the sampling strategy used to select participants and the use of semi-structured interviews as the primary method for gathering empirical material.

4.2.1 Sampling

The study uses a purposeful sampling approach, meaning that participants were strategically selected (Gentles et al., 2015, p. 1778), based on their professional roles and their direct experience with AI and journalistic work. Eight journalists, an editor-in-chief and a senior representative involved in guiding AI development at Sveriges Radio were contacted by email in order to capture perspectives from both editorial practice and organisational strategy.

Following the principle that sample size should be determined in relation to the scope of the study, the number of participants was adapted to the study's case-study design (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 470). Since the study focuses on a specific newsroom within a PSM context, the sample was shaped by the size of the newsroom and by the aim of capturing perspectives from across the editorial staff. The decision to focus on a Swedish PSM newsroom is motivated by the complex institutional environment in which it operates. While the broader news industry largely follows a market-oriented logic, PSM operate within a distinct public service logic grounded in democratic mandates and public funding (Hilker et al., 2025). Despite this different mandate, PSM organisations must still navigate and respond to the same competitive and technological pressures as commercial media (Kunert & von Nordheim, 2025; Jones et al., 2022). This dynamic can lead to forms of technological isomorphism, where organisations adopt similar practices and technologies as their competitors (Laaksonen et al., 2024; Olsen et al., 2025). Thus, the PSM context offers a particularly valuable setting for studying the implementation of AI, as it highlights how competing institutional logics intersect and shape organisational practices under distinct expectations of accountability and responsibility. The selected newsroom was also considered particularly relevant because it operates within an organisational context characterised by a self-expressed interest in innovation and technological development, including ongoing experimentation with AI tools. This provided a suitable setting for examining how AI is interpreted and integrated into journalistic practice.

4.2.2 Semi-structured Interviews

Before the interviews were conducted, an interview guide was developed. The process was iterative, with the guide being grounded in previous research while remaining flexible enough to allow new themes to emerge during the interviews. Given the importance of flexibility in capturing participants' own perspectives and experiences (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 522), the guide was designed around a framework of open-ended questions. The questions were designed to cover the main dimensions of the study, including how AI is used in everyday newsroom work, how journalists reflect on its appropriate place in journalistic practice and how they relate its use to professional responsibility and the PSM context. They also addressed participants' experiences of learning, uncertainty and support needs as AI becomes a more present part of their work. However, the interview guide was not followed rigidly, allowing space for follow-up questions and for unexpected themes to emerge during the

interviews. The interview guide was also adjusted throughout the process, as some questions were reformulated after it became evident during the interviews that certain formulations were unclear to participants.

A total of eight interviews were conducted, of which five took place via video calls on Teams and three were conducted in person on site. Prior to the interviews, participants were sent the interview guide and provided informed consent to participate in the study and to be recorded. Each interview began with an explanation of the study's purpose, the option for anonymity and the participants' right to withdraw at any time. Video calls were chosen as they made the interviews easier to conduct in terms of accessibility. Although face-to-face interviews can offer greater depth by allowing the interviewer and participant to interpret both verbal and non-verbal cues that enrich the interaction (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 537), conducting the interviews via video calls provided the flexibility necessary to accommodate logistical and time constraints. After completing the interview guide and any follow-up questions, participants were given the opportunity to provide additional input, ensuring they could raise any points they deemed important or address issues not previously covered during the interview. The interviews were transcribed on an ongoing basis, during which participants' names were also anonymised. After all interviews had been fully transcribed, the audio recordings were deleted. Table 1 presents the participants' roles, the length of each interview and the location where the interview took place. Although the participants included producers, editors and reporters, they are referred to only as journalists in the table and in the results chapter in order to protect their anonymity.

Table 1. Overview of interview participants

Participant	Role	Length	Location
R1	Journalist	44:22 min	Teams
R2	Journalist	30:24 min	Teams
R3	Journalist	22:41 min	Teams
R4	Journalist	43:01 min	Teams
R5	Journalist	33:12 min	On site
R6	Journalist	33:01 min	On site
R7	AI Strategist	36:55 min	Teams
R8	Editor-in-chief	25:33 min	On site

4.3 Analytical Approach

The analysis was conducted iteratively, beginning with careful readings of the transcripts to become familiar with the material, during which initial impressions were noted. Relevant sections were systematically coded and codes that shared similarities were grouped together to form preliminary themes. These themes were then reviewed, refined to capture their essential meaning, clearly defined, and ultimately compiled into a coherent report that interpreted the patterns in relation to the study's objectives.

4.4 Methodological Considerations

In qualitative research, methodological choices play a central role in shaping the knowledge produced and therefore require critical reflection. As this study relies on qualitative interviews within a single case study, the findings are shaped by participants' interpretations of their experiences as well as by the researcher's analytical perspective. Access to the newsroom and the willingness of participants to share their views also influence the scope and depth of the empirical material. The interview setting, the framing of questions and the interaction between researcher and participant may further shape how experiences with AI are articulated.

4.4.1 Ethical Considerations

According to the Swedish Research Council (Vetenskapsrådet, 2024), a fundamental ethical principle in research involving human participants is that individuals must be informed about the aim of the research and voluntarily consent before participating, ensuring respect for their autonomy and right to self-determination (Vetenskapsrådet, 2024, pp. 62–63). In line with this principle, all participants in this study received information about the purpose of the research, how the interviews would be conducted and how the collected data would be used. Participants were also informed that participation was voluntary and that they had the right to withdraw from the study at any time. Prior to the interviews, participants provided informed consent both to participate in the study and to have the interviews recorded. The study also follows principles related to the processing of personal data in accordance with GDPR, where participants were informed about how their personal data would be used, who would have access to the data and how long it would be stored (Bryman et al., 2025, pp. 166–167). Interviewees were also provided with relevant information about what participation involved and were given the opportunity to ask questions before and after the interviews

(Vetenskapsrådet, 2024, pp. 62–63). Audio recordings of the interviews were used solely for transcription purposes and were deleted once transcription and anonymisation had been completed. Transcripts and research materials were stored securely and only accessible to the researcher.

In order to ensure confidentiality participants were anonymised during the transcription process. Identifying information such as names and specific details that could reveal the identity of participants were generalised in the presentation of the results. Protecting participants' confidentiality was particularly important given that the study focuses on a specific newsroom, where individual roles could otherwise make participants identifiable. Anonymisation also enabled participants to speak more freely about their experiences and perspectives without fear that their responses could be traced back to them individually. This was particularly important given that the study examines organisational change and the increasing integration of AI into newsroom work, including how expectations and initiatives surrounding new ways of working may be communicated from managerial levels. In such contexts, differing opinions or tensions may emerge between employees and organisational leadership regarding the role and implementation of AI. Ensuring anonymity therefore created better conditions for participants to express critical reflections, uncertainties or disagreements openly, without concern for potential professional consequences or internal sensitivities within the organisation.

4.4.2 Credibility

Efforts were made to ensure the quality of this study based on the criteria of credibility, with emphasis on reliability, transferability, dependability and confirmability (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 443). Reliability was supported by using semi-structured interviews, allowing participants to share their experiences and perspectives in depth. The interview guide was developed iteratively, drawing on previous research while remaining flexible to capture unexpected themes, helping ensure that the findings reflect participants' realities. However, achieving full reliability in qualitative research is challenging, as interpretations are shaped by both participants and the researcher and given the difficulty of capturing and reproducing the social context precisely as it existed during the study (Bryman et al., 2025, p. 442).

In order to enhance reliability, reflexivity was applied throughout the research process, reflecting on how my own assumptions, questions and interactions could shape participants'

responses. As part of this reflexive process, I also considered my own position in relation to the research setting. Before conducting the study, I had completed an internship at Sveriges Radio. This meant that I was not entering the field as a complete outsider, since I was already familiar with parts of the organisation and had prior professional contact with some of the participants. This familiarity facilitated access to the field and may have contributed to a more open and trusting interview environment. At the same time, existing relationships may have influenced how certain experiences were articulated or interpreted. To address this, reflexivity was maintained throughout the research process, with continuous attention to how prior experiences and assumptions could shape both data collection and analysis. This was particularly important because the study aimed to understand participants' experiences of AI in journalistic practice, rather than assess their individual actions or the organisation's performance. It was further strengthened through careful documentation of all steps, clear descriptions of the methods and transparent procedures during the coding and analysis stages, ensuring that the process could be understood by others. Transferability was addressed by providing detailed descriptions of the newsroom context, including its organisational structure, size and PSM setting, as well as clear information about participant selection, such as their roles, responsibilities and involvement with AI initiatives. This level of detail allows readers to judge whether the findings may be relevant to other newsrooms or PSM organisations facing similar challenges. Full transferability is somewhat limited because participants are anonymised, which restricts the ability to link specific experiences or perspectives to individual roles. At the same time, anonymisation is necessary to uphold ethical standards and protect participants' confidentiality.

5. Results and Analysis

This chapter is structured around the study's three research questions.

- **RQ1**: How are AI tools integrated into journalistic workflows, and how do journalists describe changes in their everyday work practices?
- **RQ2**: How do journalists understand and negotiate the role and boundaries of AI use in relation to their perceptions of journalistic and public service values?
- **RQ3**: How do journalists describe the opportunities, challenges and educational needs associated with the increasing integration of AI in journalistic work?

First, section 5.1 addresses RQ1 by examining how AI tools are integrated into everyday journalistic workflows, and how respondents describe their effects on efficiency, editorial production and work practices.

Second, section 5.2 addresses RQ2 through discussions surrounding editorial responsibility, credibility, trust and the continued importance of human judgement in journalistic work.

Finally, section 5.3 addresses RQ3 by examining how journalists describe the opportunities, challenges and educational needs associated with AI integration, with particular attention to tensions surrounding competence development, professional identity and organisational expectations.

5.1 Uses of AI in Journalistic Practice

In the interviews, it became evident that AI tools have been incorporated into journalistic work to varying degrees. While the extent of use differs among respondents, all participants had either experimented with or actively used the AI tools provided by the organisation in their daily work. These tools include internally developed systems and external tools from third-party providers, as well as integrated AI functionalities embedded within existing production tools.

5.1.1 AI for Efficiency and Routine Work Processes

In the interview with the AI strategist, AI tools were framed as something that Sveriges Radio has a responsibility to adopt, particularly given the potential to enhance journalistic practice. This perspective is articulated through a focus on increasing efficiency in routine work

processes, specifically by reducing the time spent on repetitive or resource-intensive tasks that currently occupy a disproportionate part of the journalistic workflow. As the AI strategist explains:

> For example, a local reporter who can suddenly cover the local area in a much more efficient way, so I see more and more advantages with the technology (...) We need to get information out and produce important journalism, and I believe AI technology is crucial for continuing that mission in the future. (R7)

This reflects a perception that AI is becoming integral to sustaining core journalistic responsibilities, particularly in relation to the dissemination of information and the production of public-interest journalism. By framing the technology as crucial to the continuation of the journalistic mission to produce and disseminate important journalism, its legitimacy is reinforced through the obligations that define appropriate goals and behaviour (Scott, 2014, pp. 64–66). In this sense, efficiency becomes meaningful as a way of enabling journalists to fulfil core professional and public service responsibilities.

In line with this, the respondents' accounts illustrate how these ambitions materialise in practice. More specifically, the interviews highlight transcription as a key example of this, emerging as one of the most prominent and widely integrated uses of AI at Sveriges Radio. This has been made possible through the implementation of an AI-powered transcription tool available across the organisation. Several respondents emphasised how AI-driven transcription has significantly reduced the time required for processing interviews: "we have been working with AI for a very long time at Sveriges Radio when it comes to transcribing interviews, for example. That has, of course, freed up an enormous amount of time" (R8). This development was further framed in relation to manual practices, where both the discontinuity with earlier workflows and the new possibilities that arise from this shift were highlighted:

> Transcribing an entire interview used to take longer than the interview itself, since you had to type everything manually (...) so now you have the opportunity to make more journalistic judgements instead of sitting there listening to words and typing letters. (R7)

Here, AI has become integrated into everyday journalistic work to such an extent that its perceived usefulness has begun to shape routine practices. Viewed through Scott's cultural-cognitive pillar, this suggests that AI has, in certain contexts, become

institutionalised through shared meanings and taken-for-granted understandings of appropriate work practices (Scott, 2014, pp. 66–70). AI-supported transcription can therefore be understood as an example of how a specific use of AI has become normalised within the newsroom, where it is no longer treated as an exceptional innovation but as an expected and self-evident part of journalistic work. This can be understood in relation to the institutional ideology of the organisation (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849), where journalists' professional identity here is shaped by the framed mission around the ability to produce and distribute important journalism more efficiently. This is also reflected in respondents' descriptions of how the tool creates greater opportunities for journalistic assessment by saving time and changing how journalists access, navigate and engage with their material in practice:

> Our transcription service is incredibly practical and has made the work much, much more efficient. When you do a long interview and just want to find something specific somewhere in the audio file, you can locate where in the recording the person is talking about that particular thing. (R6)

Similar applications were reported by other respondents, particularly in cases where similar transcription functionalities were integrated into the video editing software they use. This usage was described as facilitating easier navigation of material: "the functions available in the programs we use (...) translating or adding subtitles are absolutely fantastic. They save an enormous, enormous amount of time" (R1). Extending this perspective, another respondent discussed how AI-powered transcription further influences video editing practices, highlighting how efficiency gains enable new conditions for execution of editorial work in practice:

> I was quite opposed to us starting to use AI for subtitling (...), but then it was like, 'oh, it takes five minutes instead of twenty-five,' and during that saved time we've actually become a bit more ambitious with our editing. (R4)

Here, initial scepticism is transformed into acceptance when AI is experienced as improving the conditions for carrying out journalistic work. Rather than being valued only for saving time, the tool becomes meaningful because the time gained can be redirected toward more careful, ambitious and editorially considered production. In this sense, the acceptance of AI is connected to the vocational dimension of journalistic identity, where journalists' motivation, professional commitment and sense of purpose are tied to producing work they themselves understand as valuable and well-crafted (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849). AI is therefore

legitimised when it supports, rather than displaces, the creative and evaluative aspects through which journalists experience their work as meaningful.

AI was also used to streamline other language-related tasks, where respondents also described how AI is applied in other areas such as summarising longer texts, translation and proofreading. Proofreading in particular was highlighted by some respondents, who referred to the use of an internally developed AI tool that enables the creation of customised AI agents based on predefined rules and training data:

> I use, and so do all the editors, an AI agent that we have created for proofreading and copy-editing, which makes my job much easier. Instead of just sitting there looking for spelling and grammatical errors, I can focus more on the editorial aspects, like how what we write might be interpreted by the audience. (R1)

These accounts demonstrate how AI has made certain tasks more efficient, thereby creating more time and focus for other aspects of editorial work. In this sense, efficiency gains are closely linked to a shift in work practices, where routine activities are increasingly handled by AI while editorial judgement is given greater prominence.

Another area where respondents described AI as influencing their journalistic practice was the research process. Several respondents described using external AI tools such as ChatGPT or Claude in ways that resemble traditional search engines, but with notable differences. In particular, some respondents highlighted that these tools are sometimes more effective when searching for highly specific information. Similarly, one respondent described using AI to quickly gain an overview of recent media coverage within specific news areas:

> Then I also use AI in the morning when I make a morning overview. I ask something like ChatGPT, 'What have Swedish media reported about health and studies over the past 24 hours?' (R6)

While the respondent noted that the quality of this process was uneven, with the AI at times proving less reliable, they also described it as facilitating the identification and retrieval of relevant material in other instances. This was evident in the AI's ability to generate suggestions for potential interview subjects within a given topic area.:

> That's also an efficiency gain, instead of calling universities and asking if there's someone who might be willing to talk about this (...) It can always be a jungle, so it can

> really help to get suggestions for different doctors or researchers who have talked about this before and have researched various interesting things. (R6)

Another respondent described a similar experience, where AI enabled a form of research that would otherwise not have been feasible due to time and practical constraints: "I have become much more efficient, absolutely. I find sources that I probably wouldn't have found otherwise, simply because I can't go through that amount of material" (R3). These examples reflect a broader pattern in the respondents' accounts, where AI is primarily welcomed when it supports already established journalistic tasks. In these cases, AI is understood as a tool that can streamline repetitive and routine aspects of the work, reducing the time and effort required without replacing the journalist's core role. This makes it possible for respondents to redirect attention and resources toward other dimensions of journalism, particularly tasks involving editorial judgement and more evaluative forms of work.

5.1.2 Expanded Journalistic Practices

Some interviewees further described how AI-driven efficiency enabled forms of work that would previously not have been feasible. In this sense, some journalists saw AI as something that could expand the practical conditions for carrying out journalistic tasks. This was particularly evident in relation to more advanced data-oriented work:

> I recently did something where I could scrape all the party leaders' Instagram posts and then put them into a database, and then use a model that goes through them… there were thousands of posts, and it categorised the posts based on what kind of political issue they were talking about. (R2)

In this sense, AI was perceived as extending journalistic work by making large volumes of material more manageable and analytically accessible. This also allowed respondents to identify patterns, categories and possible inconsistencies in material that would otherwise have been difficult to process manually, as another respondent further states:

> I worked on a project (...) first we went through the data, and then we used AI to check whether we had missed anything. It found a few mistakes, which we then double-checked and corrected based on that. (R6)

This expansion of AI-supported analysis was also reflected in more formalised project-based work, where respondents described content analysis with AI as a new practice that had not previously been carried out at the organisation:

> We currently have an election project running where we are going to do content analysis using AI. No one at Sveriges Radio has done that before. It has been a bit tricky to reach the right people, because we also need developers who can build some things for us and so on. (R8)

Here, respondents' descriptions suggest that reductions in manual labour expand what journalists are practically able to examine, both in terms of analytical depth and breadth, within the constraints of newsroom resources and time. This can be interpreted as illustrating a further step in the development of AI-supported journalistic practices, moving beyond efficiency gains toward more experimental and infrastructural forms of work. Rather than simply assisting with individual tasks, AI was seen by respondents as enabling new forms of journalistic practice, as it made it possible to work with scales of material that would previously not have been practically attainable in this context.

The respondents also expressed how similar developments are beginning to shape the writing and the idea process itself, where it is used to facilitate new ways of generating and refining journalistic content. This was particularly facilitated through the organisation's internally developed AI tool:

> We now have our own tool, Prompto, which I use, and I've created my own agent in it that helps with proofreading and suggests alternative ways of writing a post. (R2)

Other respondents likewise described it as a sounding board and a practical resource for assisting colleagues in their work:

> I sometimes use AI to find angles for, well, morning meetings or when I'm running larger meetings. (...) I also use it quite a lot as a way to brainstorm when reporters have gotten stuck. (R8)

By developing an AI agent trained on internal editorial practices, specifically by feeding it examples of how journalists approach tasks, including the stylistic elements used by the newsroom, the system can be shaped to reflect the newsroom's way of working:

> It is supposed to come up with suggestions, it can be about tone or a more lively way of phrasing something. It has been given quite a lot of texts so that it can compare or form an idea of what we usually do, it works relatively well. (R1)

In this context, another respondent described developing an AI agent to assist in drafting scripts for news broadcasts, where it generates initial versions of short-form segments intended to be read on air:

> I'm currently building a kind of Telegram agent. I'm still not completely satisfied with it, but I think it is better than a newly hired employee. However, I think it is much worse than someone who has worked here for a very long time. So I believe it can be useful for first drafts, especially perhaps for summer interns who are new, but it could not replace anyone on the editorial team. (R8)

This suggests a movement from AI being used mainly for efficiency toward its use as support in more experimental forms of editorial work. In this way, the agent functions as an intermediary layer between established editorial practices and practical content production. In this case it is suggested that the system is primarily positioned as an entry-level support tool, particularly valuable in the earliest stages of production where drafting assistance is most needed. If AI is seen as especially useful for tasks normally associated with newcomers or interns, this raises questions about how entry-level journalistic competence may be developed and evaluated. While the respondent clearly states that the tool could not replace experienced members of the editorial team, the comparison with newly hired employees suggests that AI may become involved in precisely those early-stage tasks through which journalists usually learn newsroom routines.

This understanding of AI as a support tool in early-stage production also extends to other new editorial practices in everyday work. It becomes embedded in workflows that allow journalists to handle tasks they would otherwise be uncertain about or less familiar with. In this sense, AI enables learning-in-practice by making unfamiliar material more accessible to work with:

> Subtitling and transcribing, one example is when our correspondent has filmed material that is in Spanish, and he also sends a translation. But when I need to subtitle that Spanish into Swedish, I don't always know exactly what is being said, so I usually use the AI translation in Adobe Premiere Pro to cross-check against the original translation we've received. (R1)

Here, AI can be seen as modestly altering the practical conditions of journalistic production by enabling new forms of mediated work. R3 talked about using AI to learn coding through so-called "vibe coding", where the system functions as an intermediary that generates code based on prompts rather than the user writing it manually. In this sense, AI was seen as a contributor to competence development by introducing new ways of approaching work and expanding the methods available for carrying out journalistic tasks. This is further reflected in accounts from other respondents, who emphasise how observing others learn new skills through AI can itself be engaging, and can spark an awareness of the different possibilities the technology opens up for journalistic work:

> Like, 'look how cool this is, my colleague coded something that turned into a really awesome thing, she can't code so she wouldn't have been able to do it otherwise,' and then you're like, damn that's cool, could we do something similar and stuff like that. (R4)

This illustrates how AI outputs can challenge assumptions about required expertise, prompting journalists to reconsider how certain tasks can be approached and who is able to perform them within their work context. Understood from the concept of organisational work (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849), this suggests that AI may affect journalistic identity by altering the practical conditions of work, showing the two-way relationship of the technology (Orlikowski, 1992, p. 406). When new tasks become accessible through AI, the boundaries of journalists' everyday responsibilities may shift. Therefore, AI may also expand what journalists perceive themselves as capable of doing within their professional role.

Overall, the respondents describe AI in journalistic practice as serving multiple purposes, ranging from efficiency gains in routine work to the emergence of new editorial and creative practices. While they primarily associate current use with saving time and reducing repetitive tasks, they also express that AI is beginning to expand what is practically possible in their work. In their accounts, this is reflected both in how existing tasks are carried out and in how they perceive changes in learning, problem-solving and content production in everyday journalistic practice. However, this framing may also invite further reflection on the role of efficiency as a journalistic value. Respondents describe AI as potentially freeing up time for editorial judgement, yet the interviews give less attention to how such efficiency gains may shape expectations around productivity and the pace of news production. From the perspective of the duality of technology (Orlikowski, 1992, p. 406), the increasing integration of AI into newsroom routines may gradually influence organisational assumptions about what

can reasonably be achieved within existing workflows. If tasks that were previously time-consuming come to be seen as faster or more easily manageable, AI-supported efficiency may contribute to redefining what counts as a normal or reasonable workload. This raises questions about whether efficiency primarily strengthens editorial work, or whether it may also risk normalising intensified productivity demands within the newsroom.

Another question worth considering is whether and, if so, how these uses of AI may shape editorial judgement before the final decision-making stage. This is particularly relevant in relation to research processes and AI-supported analysis of large datasets, where the technology can help identify sources, patterns and connections that would otherwise be difficult to detect within the available time. While this expands what journalists are practically able to examine, it also raises questions about how editorial attention is directed. Especially when external AI tools are used, the processes through which certain sources, patterns or interpretations are made visible may be difficult for journalists to fully assess. In this sense, AI may influence the informational basis upon which journalistic assessments are made, raising broader questions about how technological support relates to editorial responsibility. This issue occupied a central place in the interviews, particularly as respondents reflected on how journalistic responsibility can be maintained as AI becomes increasingly integrated into newsroom practice.

5.2 Interpretations and Attitudes Toward AI

Building on the increasing incorporation of AI tools into journalistic work across the organisation, this section addresses the second research question by examining how respondents understand AI's role and negotiate the boundaries of when, how and whether it should be used in relation to their perceptions of journalistic and public service values. At the same time, it also begins to address the third research question, as respondents' reflections on appropriate AI use are closely connected to questions of knowledge, training and the need to understand the technology in order to use it responsibly. The interviews reveal both shared perspectives and points of variation in how the technology is understood and situated within professional practice. While there was broad alignment regarding the role AI should play in journalism, the degree of acceptance differed among respondents. These similarities and differences become particularly visible in how respondents articulate the boundaries of AI use, its relationship to professional responsibility and its implications for journalistic practice.

5.2.1 Multiple Grounds for Human Involvement

This section shows that respondents justified human involvement through several overlapping concerns; responsibility, audience trust, editorial quality, journalistic knowledge and AI literacy.

Across these concerns, respondents consistently defined AI as a tool that must remain guided and limited by human judgement. Rather than treating AI as an autonomous actor in journalistic work, they understood its appropriate use through the professional values and responsibilities they perceive structure journalism. Several respondents drew a clear distinction between AI as a support tool and journalism as a human practice: “journalism is in many ways a craft, there are so many aspects of doing journalism that I don’t think AI can fully replace” (R1). Similarly, another respondent stated: “AI must not replace real journalists, I think that’s very important. AI can help me a lot, but what AI is really bad at is being a journalist” (R2). Thus, respondents partly defined the limits of AI in technical terms, perceiving it as insufficient, while also linking these limitations to the view of journalism as a fundamentally human craft. Authorship was understood as something tied to human judgement and accountability, positioning AI as a tool that may support journalistic work rather than as an actor capable of replacing the journalist. This relates to the cultural-cognitive pillar of institutions, where it can be argued that the human journalist is taken for granted as central to the production of meaning and accountability (Scott, 2014, pp. 66–70). In this sense, the boundaries of AI use can be argued to be shaped by a shared perception that journalism remains a fundamentally human practice, even as technological tools become increasingly integrated into the work process.

This understanding of journalism as fundamentally human was partly reflected in how respondents discussed responsibility and editorial control. Several respondents placed strong value on being able to stand behind journalistic output as its author: “I would never let an AI create content in my name” (R3). Further, R6 emphasised that this has always been an important principle: “just because an AI writes it, you can’t just trust it, you always have to check the source, and also think for yourself about the language being used”. Similarly, R1 explained that even when a news text has been processed through an AI agent, they would still proofread it and ensure that the tone matches the newsroom’s style. These statements point to a shared understanding that responsibility does not move from the journalist to the technology. Here, considerable importance is placed on ensuring that AI-generated or

AI-assisted material is assessed and verified through professional judgement before becoming part of the journalistic output.

This boundary-setting was particularly visible in relation to generative AI and synthetic voices. R7 explained that the organisation had decided not to use synthetic voices in produced content, as this was not seen as necessary or in line with its values and policy. Respondents expressed strong support for this approach, viewing it as an important safeguard of how journalism is practised and experienced:

> One wants to position oneself as credible, and that every time you hear a public service radio programme, you should know that it is a real voice. I agree with that 100 percent. (R3)

This boundary-setting can be understood through both the regulatory and normative pillars (Scott, 2014, pp. 64–70). On the one hand, formal rules and policies define what kinds of AI use are permitted or restricted. On the other hand, respondents' emphasis on human presence and editorial responsibility reflects normative expectations about what journalism should be and who should remain accountable for it. This combination of formal regulation and professional norms emerged as a consistent pattern across the interviews. The normative function was for example illustrated by how AI is embedded within a socially negotiated practice:

> I ask my closest colleagues to try it out, to practice it a bit when they write posts and so on. It's getting better and better, which is fun, but I keep telling everyone a hundred times: don't fully trust it, because it's not as good at Swedish as you are. (R2)

In this way, AI becomes something that is continuously mediated, rather than operating as an independent contributor to journalistic work. By discussing and framing the use of AI tools with colleagues, and repeatedly reminding others to remain cautious of the tool's linguistic limitations, human judgement could be argued to be positioned as the standard against which AI-generated material must be evaluated.

Further, this boundary-setting was also evident in relation to external trust, particularly through concerns about how AI use may be perceived by audiences. As the editor-in-chief explains:

> I mean, trust is the most important thing we have. We can't go around testing and just publish AI summaries, or replace our voices (...) The AI transition might be happening a bit more slowly, but that might also be good, so that you don't make a lot of mistakes in public that affect trust. (R8)

Similarly, R1 expressed a related concern, arguing that if journalism repeatedly publishes AI-generated or manipulated material, it risks failing in its fundamental mission. Another respondent further added:

> If I see, for example, that a news article is entirely AI-written, I don't think I would read it, I would move on. I also think many listeners, viewers and readers are the same. (R4)

This suggests that journalists' perceptions of AI are partly shaped by an anticipated audience reaction and if the public will accept as legitimate journalism. From the perspective of PSM legitimacy, this shows how AI is evaluated in relation to public recognition and trust, rather than technological capacity alone (Puppis & Ali, 2023; Fehlmann, 2023). Journalists' caution can therefore be understood as an attempt to protect PSM's democratic authority, where even the appearance of replacing human judgement may risk weakening the public value on which the institution depends. This indicates that broader claims about audience trust can function as a powerful professional argument, one that is partly imagined through journalists' own expectations of the audience. Thus, AI becomes limited in advance by what journalists believe the public will accept as legitimate journalism.

A further ground for human involvement concerned the perceived creative and qualitative limits of AI-generated output. Several respondents described the internal AI agents as useful, but not yet capable of capturing the expressive and situated qualities of journalistic communication:

> It's that it's not very creative yet and has difficulty summarising a longer text into something snappy, and maybe it doesn't really know what that means (...) I often think that our AI agents are quite rigid and clumsy, in terms of tone or writing style, so to speak. (R5)

This view was further reinforced when attempts to train AI agents on the newsroom's own style still failed to produce material that met their editorial expectations:

> We did that workshop where we uploaded 30 TikTok scripts, where the tone is a certain way and that's how we try to write. It should have personality, some tone and a bit of flair

> in the language. Then it was supposed to come back with suggestions for a script, and what we got in return were completely crazy suggestions. It just became so incredibly robotic, it was awful. (R1)

This perception of AI's limited creative quality also became particularly clear when comparing it to how the newsroom defines its own way of working and the quality standards it sets for itself:

> There is no AI that, at least for now, can write such a human script based on how we work (...) we are so inherently human in what we deliver to the audience, and I think that also makes our newsroom stand out. (R2)

Beyond concerns related to accountable AI use described previously, these accounts further connect audience legitimacy to the newsroom's ability to maintain a recognisable editorial voice. AI is therefore perceived as inadequate when it threatens the distinctiveness through which the newsroom understands and presents its journalism. Following Raemy (2021), human writing can be understood as an expression of both professional competence and the normative values that distinguish the newsroom's work. The rejection of robotic AI outputs thus reflects a defence of journalism as vocation and institutional practice, while also functioning as professional boundary work.

This distinction between AI-supported tasks and core journalistic work further emerged in relation to epistemological questions about fieldwork and human interaction, as R4 states:

> What is it that we humans can do that AI cannot do? Well, it's going out and talking to people, and that part of the journalist's work will never disappear. Journalism exists for people, and it's about human destinies and human lives. (R4)

The boundary drawn around AI use therefore concerns what can be recognised as journalistic knowledge. This indicates that journalistic knowledge extends beyond the mere collection of information, including interpreting situations and responding to people in ways that require judgement shaped by experience. In this sense, the boundary is both technical and epistemological, concerning what counts as knowledge and how it is produced within journalism.

These ideas about journalistic knowledge shaped how respondents discussed AI within everyday routines, where its use is embedded in established practices of evaluation and editorial judgement. As one respondent explains:

> Here caution is very sensible I think. As a journalist, you should be somewhat sceptical (...) this is a technology that can be used to improve journalism in various ways, and we need to test it, but it is often not yet where we want it to be. (...) You need knowledge to use it correctly. It's not as simple as just writing 'find out about this' and then automatically getting a good journalistic answer that holds up, it still requires a lot of checking and work. (R7)

This process is stated to require more than simply using the tool, as it also depends on an understanding of how the AI operates. Therefore, such knowledge is stated to be necessary to apply it appropriately within journalistic work. This need for understanding and careful use is also stated to be situated within a broader professional framework, where established practices continue to guide how new tools are handled in production. As the AI strategist explains:

> In the end, it really comes down to journalistic method, meaning that even before AI tools (...) we often had to verify things. We've had routines for that for a very long time. We do a lot of line-by-line checks when we carry out major investigations. In other words, we use the journalistic method that we are all trained in, and it is perhaps the same method we use to check the tools as well. (R7)

Here, AI is situated within a broader continuity of journalism as a human-centred practice, where established methods of verification and scrutiny are stated to remain central regardless of technological change. According to the strategist, there is not necessarily a perceived need to introduce entirely new forms of evaluation, as AI is integrated into existing routines where professional standards serve as a stabilising framework for adopting new tools. This view expressed by the strategist was largely reflected across the other interviews as well.

However, confidence in human oversight did not remove concerns about uneven levels of AI understanding among staff. In particular, there was an awareness that not all users may fully grasp how AI systems function or what their use entails in practice:

> I wish people would really go into depth and learn how AI works under the hood. Take the time to have it explained in a way that they find both interesting and fun. Because I

> think that right now many people are just like, 'no, that's not for me, it's too advanced and a bit scary.' I would like everyone to have the time to really sit down and do that, not just in between broadcasts, so to speak. (R3)

Engagement with AI is here perceived as remaining at a relatively surface level, where users may avoid deeper understanding due to perceptions of complexity or intimidation. Thus, meaningful use of AI is seen as requiring more than trust in journalists' critical and knowledgeable abilities, with a human-in-the-loop approach alone being insufficient to ensure safe and effective use. While all respondents emphasise the importance of maintaining human oversight and professional judgement, it became evident that they still perceived a need for greater understanding and education about how AI systems work in practice. This may suggest that safe and confident integration of AI into journalistic work is also linked to developing deeper technical and methodological literacy, which becomes a key issue moving forward into discussions of AI integration and training requirements.

5.2.2 Developing Journalistic Competence for AI Integration

There is a clear consensus among the respondents that the integration of AI within the organisation requires continuous education. Across the interviews, training emerges as a central mechanism for preparing journalists for the increasing presence of AI in everyday work, while also shaping understandings of appropriate use. At the same time, the interviews reveal tensions between standardised training formats and the situated nature of journalistic practice, suggesting that AI literacy develops unevenly across roles and levels of experience.

Across the interviews, AI is frequently understood as an inevitable development that will increasingly influence everyday journalistic work. This perception is closely linked to a sense that the organisation must proactively prepare for its integration. As one respondent explains: "If we assume that this will become a much larger part of the job, I think there will soon be a need for more training" (R1). This view of insufficient understanding of AI's functions and limitations can lead to ineffective and potentially problematic use was not only expressed by the journalists themselves, but was also reflected in how Sveriges Radio has approached the broader implementation of AI. As highlighted by the AI strategist, education is positioned as a central component for enabling successful AI adoption, rather than as a supplementary support measure:

> Very early on, we had an AI course (...) for everyone, specifically to highlight the risks, because it was clear that these services were now available and journalists would probably start testing them (...) the most important thing for us was really to have clear training that emphasises the risks. (R7)

As reflected in the quote, there is an implicit assumption that journalists would inevitably begin experimenting with AI tools as they became more accessible. In this sense, AI is understood as already becoming part of everyday practice. The organisation's response, implementing training for the entire workforce, can therefore be understood as an effort to anticipate and structure this development, reflecting a regulatory dimension (Scott, 2014, pp. 59–64), as the organisation attempts to create internal conditions for responsible use, and shared expectations around how AI should be handled in journalistic work.

This anticipation of widespread use is closely tied to a strong emphasis on risk assessment, particularly in relation to how AI tools might be used in practice:

> If we start with the risks, it's that you might have an inadequate tool that you also trust too much. That is a clear risk, meaning that you have a tool that doesn't really deliver correct information, and then you end up believing that information, that is an obvious risk. (R7)

This suggests an understanding of AI as a technology that demands careful assessment and clear guidance, moving beyond a purely neutral framing of the tool. Training therefore serves to build competence while also framing appropriate use and establishing boundaries for responsible practice, particularly in an increasingly AI-integrated everyday context. To build this knowledge, training is provided through an online course on the organisation's intranet that all employees are expected to complete, as well as through practical workshops. In the interviews it was a recurring theme where respondents described the organisation training and educational initiative as positive:

> These courses were really just about understanding it, partly what you can use it for, but also what kinds of concerns there are (...) and it still felt good that those things were brought up, that has felt reassuring. (R4)

More than focusing solely on technical skills, the educational approach was perceived to have introduced AI in a balanced manner, where opportunities and limitations were presented as part of the same learning process. This dual framing may also contribute to the perceived

legitimacy of the initiative, as transparency regarding risks seems to strengthen trust in the training. Beyond fostering trust, some respondents also viewed the workshops as particularly valuable in an engaging way, as they provided a pragmatic form of learning through observing how others apply AI in practice. As one respondent noted: "the lectures that everyone has attended about AI and how it is used in practice in different jobs have been very valuable" (R1). Another respondent expressed a similar view:

> He was like, 'I had this large body of material, it would have taken me several days to go through it, I practised asking an AI questions, and then I got an angle out of it.' And I still felt that either I wouldn't have been able to do that, or it would have taken an incredibly long time. So I think they've been quite good at communicating what this is what we intend to use it for. (R4)

By demonstrating how AI can support tasks that would otherwise be highly time-consuming, such examples contribute to a shift in how the feasibility of certain forms of work is perceived, while also influencing the broader entry point and engagement with AI. This may be understood as easing the AI integration by presenting the technology as compatible with journalistic commitments to reliability and public trust, rather than as a disruption of professional practice. In this way, AI could be argued to become legitimised through its alignment with the broader institutional understanding of what journalism is supposed to achieve (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849). This also highlights the importance of peer-based learning, where observing colleagues' applications of AI enables a more grounded understanding than abstract instruction alone. This perspective was further echoed at higher levels of the organisation, where AI implementation was not necessarily framed as requiring a uniform or tightly structured approach:

> I don't think there is, well (...) a strategy that has in any real sense reached the newsrooms, and that we are all working with this in a very structured way, I don't experience that at all, and I'm not even sure it necessarily needs to be like that either. (R8)

This places greater responsibility on the individual journalist to identify relevant use cases, suggesting a more decentralised and self-directed approach to AI adoption. While this approach is largely viewed positively by the journalists, particularly in terms of its openness and encouragement of exploration, it is also accompanied by a perceived need for more structured guidance and support by some respondents:

> But it's a lot of like 'play around, experiment, figure it out', and I think it's fun that it's encouraged, but you also need more guidance (...) I mean, for example, that you could meet an AI coach once a month for like half an hour. (R6)

While autonomy and exploration are encouraged, the quote suggests that relying primarily on individual initiative risks placing excessive responsibility on journalists to navigate complex tools without sufficient scaffolding. The expressed need for more continuous interaction further indicates that current training efforts may struggle to keep pace with the evolving nature of AI-related competencies. In this sense, the findings support previous research emphasising journalists' demand for forms of AI literacy grounded in critical understanding rather than purely technical instruction (Couraceiro et al., 2025; Jones et al., 2022). The findings also extend this perspective by showing how the absence of ongoing organisational support may shift responsibility for developing such competencies onto individual journalists themselves. As a result, some journalists may find it more difficult to begin using AI or to identify how the technology can be practically implemented in relation to their specific work tasks.

Given the relative novelty of the technology and its expanding range of applications, the respondents perceive this as part of a broader sense that existing levels of knowledge remain insufficient, pointing toward an ongoing need for further development and deeper understanding:

> Given that this is so new for so many people, using AI in different ways, I also think there is a need for more than what has already been provided at Sveriges Radio (...) I think there is a lot of general information out there about how AI works. (R1)

This points to a distinction between general available information about AI and the more situated understanding needed for its practical application. It also suggests that existing initiatives are viewed as a starting point rather than a comprehensive solution, highlighting the early and evolving nature of AI-related competence within the organisation. In this sense, it underscores a broader need to strengthen AI literacy, particularly in fostering a deeper and more critical understanding of AI's underlying mechanisms and implications for use, as one respondent states:

> I think you have to be very careful, because many people don't know how AI works. Many don't know who gets access to the material you upload to AI services, or the

> difference between doing something locally and in the cloud, for example. Many don't know how basic things AI can get wrong, even though it is often very convincing when it is wrong. So I think there should be even more focus on continuing education in AI, and maybe more advanced training. (R3)

This statement further points to a percieved uneven distribution of AI-related knowledge within the organisation, where not all employees are equally equipped to engage with the technology. It also highlights how important aspects of AI systems may remain opaque to users, which may complicate responsible use. This suggests a gap between access to AI tools and the competence required to use them effectively, raising the possibility of unintentional misuse. In this sense, the need extends beyond basic familiarity toward a deeper form of understanding that includes awareness of the technological and infrastructural conditions shaping AI outputs. This perspective is further developed by another respondent, especially in light of the continued evolution of AI:

> That is probably the biggest challenge for journalism right now, not how we should use it or how we can increasingly get help from it, but I think the biggest challenge is being able to verify things. I think that is the main challenge now: what is correct, real, authentic, and what is not. (R1)

This shifts the focus from practical application to epistemological concerns, where the ability to assess credibility becomes central in an AI-influenced media environment. While AI has so far primarily been positioned as a tool for efficiency, this also highlights how its presence is influences core journalistic practices related to verification and truth claims. This is intensified by what the respondent perceives as the increasing sophistication of AI-generated content, which makes it more difficult to distinguish between authentic and fabricated material. This concern is not perceived as limited to the local newsroom, but rather as part of a broader challenge affecting journalism more widely. Even established and highly trusted international news organisations are expressed to face increasing difficulty in managing and verifying AI-generated or manipulated content:

> The further the technology develops, the more likely it is that different news media will fall for such things and publish something that is AI-generated or manipulated in some way (...) It is troubling that manipulated material can exist in news agencies' databases, especially something like Reuters, which is still so highly reputable. (R1)

From this perspective, it points to a structural vulnerability in news production systems that extends beyond isolated errors. Therefore, AI literacy is seen as an essential critical skill set for navigating increasingly ambiguous information landscapes:

> I think it is fundamentally positive for those who are at the forefront. You become more alert, because everything is happening very quickly now, and if you work more actively with it, I would say that you then have a slight head start all the time. (R1)

In this sense, the need for AI literacy is linked to a potential professional advantage, suggesting that those who actively engage with and develop their understanding of AI may be better positioned in a rapidly changing environment. Some respondents saw initiatives and engagement as important for keeping pace with ongoing developments. In this regard, several expressed a generally positive view of how Sveriges Radio approaches AI, particularly in a cautious and deliberate manner. This was often understood as a way of ensuring that training efforts are grounded in long-term considerations, signaling both organisational support and a commitment to responsible knowledge development:

> I'm still positively inclined towards the fact that Sveriges Radio has taken its time because they really want to do this in a safe way and not just rush things out. (...) But they still think in terms of making it secure and sustainable. You don't do something just so it exists for two or three days; you do it safely for the future, so to speak. (R2)

However, many also felt that the training did not sufficiently account for varying levels of prior knowledge, which shaped perceptions of its overall adequacy. Nearly all respondents felt that the education provided was too basic and lacking in depth:

> For me, the training we have received at Sveriges Radio hasn't given me anything. I can understand that if you are very, very new to AI it might be useful. But otherwise I think it is too basic. (R3)

This also manifested in a preference for more context-specific training that could be adjusted according to different levels of competence:

> It would probably be nice if the training could exist at different levels, for those who don't know anything at all, maybe gathering together, and those of us who are moderately skilled could do it together. (R5)

Furthermore, several respondents also highlighted time constraints as a factor contributing to the perception that it was insufficient:

> We got AI coaches here, and they were here for like two hours and then that was it. (...) About 15 people in a room, and they went through how they did things, and you weren't really allowed to ask your own questions about your own ideas. (R6)

This was also evident in how the training was perceived as following a 'one-size-fits-all' approach, with limited adaptation to the specific needs of individual newsrooms:

> It hasn't felt like it has been very tailored to our newsroom, but rather to the whole organisation, and it didn't give that much. It has still been at a fairly basic level, it is still a bit too general. (R6)

This suggests a limited degree of contextualisation, which may reduce opportunities for deeper engagement with AI in relation to specific journalistic work tasks. As a result, it was often experienced as overly general and insufficiently tailored to the practical realities of the respondents' own editorial context: "there is a need to talk specifically, in one's own role, about how to actually use it oneself" (R6). This highlights a perceived need for more role-specific reflection on how AI can be meaningfully integrated into everyday work practices.

While respondents in other parts of the material describe the workshops as particularly valuable when they showcase concrete examples of AI use across journalistic tasks, these quotes suggest that such relevance is not always self-evident at the individual level. This indicates that different journalistic roles may shape how easily journalists are able to translate general AI knowledge into practical application. From the perspective of interpretive flexibility (Orlikowski, 1992, pp. 407–408), the use of AI is therefore mediated by the specific work context in which journalists encounter it, including their professional tasks, prior knowledge, motivations and the organisational conditions that guide newsroom practice. This indicates that different journalistic roles may shape how easily journalists are able to translate general AI knowledge into practical application. AI could be argued to not acquire a fixed meaning simply by being introduced into the newsroom, instead, its usefulness is shaped through the concrete situations in which journalists encounter it. The same AI tool may therefore appear relevant and practical to some roles, while remaining distant or difficult to apply for others. The findings primarly suggest that this difference is closely connected to

how easily AI can be translated into concrete journalistic tasks within specific roles. As one respondent states:

> I've been thinking a lot about how I should use AI in my role. Because that's also the thing, my manager has asked me to do it, but I'm not really sure what it is supposed to contribute right now. (R5)

This points to a sense of external expectation without clear operational grounding, where AI use is encouraged from a managerial level but not yet fully translated into concrete editorial practice. This suggests a transitional stage in AI adoption, where exploration is ongoing but clear anchoring in everyday workflows and role-specific functions is perceived to be less evident. What is visible here is the tension of the journalists own vocation and the newsrooms institutional ideology (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849), where a form of uncertainty is present about relevance. Here the respondent is actively reflecting on alignment between organisational expectations and perceived journalistic value. Rather than being primarily a matter of access to tools or formal training, AI integration could be argued to also be shaped by how journalistic roles and perceived relevance interact in everyday practice.

5.3 Tensions in Learning AI

Building on the understanding of AI literacy as a differentiated and context-dependent capacity, this section addresses the third research question by examining how respondents describe the opportunities and challenges associated with AI's increasing presence in journalistic work. While access to tools and organisational training can support engagement with AI, the interviews show that learning is also shaped by varying levels of willingness and uncertainty. AI integration can therefore be understood as a process marked by tension rather than straightforward progression. As AI becomes more embedded in newsroom routines, different orientations toward the technology emerge, where possibilities for developing journalistic work coexist with concerns about professional boundaries and ethical responsibility. This section explores these tensions in relation to journalistic norms, ethical positioning, organisational expectations and professional insecurity.

5.3.1 Normative Boundaries of Journalism and AI Use

In the newsroom, journalistic norms become particularly visible in how journalists emotionally and practically relate to the potential influences of their work through AI. In this

sense, resistance emerges from a normative commitment to journalism as a skilled and creative practice. This concern is expressed by a respondent, who links the growing presence of AI in journalistic production to a perceived shift in the character of journalism itself:

> Purely emotionally, I think that if AI replaces journalists, journalism will become more boring (…) it's just like when you read something that's AI-written or watch AI clips and things like that, I think it's boring. There's a kind of distance to it. (R6)

This illustrates how resistance to AI is shaped by personal normative expectations of what journalism should be (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849). The perception of AI-generated content as "boring" and "distant" reflects an underlying view that journalism ought to foster closeness with its audience. This concern is further illustrated by another respondent, who links extensive AI use in published journalism to questions of transparency, authorship and reader trust:

> I read this from a major news outlet (…) he wrote, like about economics or something, giving tips, and then it turned out that all his texts were just AI. And that's when I think you should be clear about whether, I mean, if such a large share is just spat out by a model. (R2)

What becomes central is the sense that journalistic content should feel humanly mediated, engaging and trustworthy, where meaning is produced through a recognisable authorial presence. When AI is associated with reduced emotional resonance or perceived authenticity, it is interpreted as altering the experiential dimension of journalism itself, potentially weakening the connection between content and audience. This also helps explain why concerns about undisclosed AI use can be experienced as a breach of trust, since it disrupts expectations about transparency and the human origin of journalistic work. This is further reflected by a respondent who relates these expectations directly to their own writing practice and professional identity:

> That's why I wouldn't use AI, because I think it damages my personal tone, and I don't want to speak in a way that isn't my own voice. That's also what I enjoy about my job, being able to write in this way. I wouldn't be allowed to write like this if I worked at, say, Expressen or somewhere like that. So I don't think you should take it for granted. And I absolutely don't want someone else doing it for me. It's not that fun. (R4)

This can be read as expressing a form of boundary-making where AI is evaluated through its potential impact on the journalist's professional identity (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849), rather than its technical usefulness. This also introduces an affective dimension, where the value of journalistic work is connected to enjoyment and creative engagement. From this perspective, resistance is about preserving the experiential aspects of writing as a practice. This concern also extends to how increasing reliance on AI is perceived to affect the development and maintenance of abilities considered central to journalistic practice. From this perspective, the unease surrounding AI is connected to the idea that skills must be continuously exercised in order to remain meaningful parts of the profession, rather than gradually being delegated to automated systems over time, as one respondent explains:

> I think the biggest thing is that I'm afraid that my colleagues and I will lose journalistic skills like thinking independently, being able to process text ourselves, coming up with a good headline, proofreading, or, well, everything that an AI can do. So then maybe you stop developing those abilities, and I don't think that's good for professional development. (R6)

This reflects a concern that the growing integration of AI may alter the conditions through which journalistic expertise is developed and sustained over time. This can be understood through the concept of the duality of technology, where technology is both shaped by human use and, in turn, shapes work practices and professional roles (Orlikowski, 1992, p. 406). AI is described as useful because it can support journalists in carrying out certain tasks more efficiently, but the fear of losing journalistic competence also shows how the technology may gradually influence what skills are valued and expected. In this sense, the concern is that the professional knowledge connected to those tasks may become less central if they are increasingly delegated to automated systems. When these processes become increasingly automated, there is a perceived risk that the profession itself may shift toward a more supervisory role, where journalists rely on AI-generated outputs rather than actively developing their own editorial capacities. Here, resistance to AI stems from concerns about how professional vocational standards (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849) are maintained and reproduced within everyday journalistic work, rather than just from scepticism toward the technology alone. In the interviews, these concerns also extended beyond present newsroom practices to broader questions about how journalistic knowledge and competence should be cultivated in the future, as the AI strategist states:

> It's a challenging and interesting issue for journalism education and journalists. How much should you force people to write by hand, so to speak, without other tools? How much do you learn from that? (R7)

In this sense, the integration of AI raises questions about how future journalists are expected to learn, develop and maintain core journalistic abilities. These reflections point to a broader tension concerning what journalism fundamentally is and how journalistic authority is.

These raised concerns relate deeply to the belief that professional judgement emerges through the actual practice of writing, editing, interpreting and making decisions independently. From this perspective, journalistic competence can be understood as something continuously produced through active engagement with the craft itself. This also reveals how defined appropriate goals and behaviour (Scott, 2014, pp. 64–66) shape the boundaries of acceptable AI integration. In line with an earlier respondent's reaction to fully AI-generated journalistic content, another respondent reflects on the idea that a colleague might increasingly rely on AI in their journalistic work, which raises concerns about acceptable professional practice:

> I never hear things like, 'yeah, I let an AI write everything for me,' or that kind of thing. That would frustrate me a bit, I think I would probably say something if that was the case. (R4)

The value placed on independent judgement, editorial responsibility and intellectual labour creates a normative expectation that journalists should remain actively involved in the production process. In practice, these expectations are embedded in newsroom culture as informal regulatory norms, where AI is assessed through shared and often unspoken assumptions about acceptable professional conduct among colleagues. Resistance therefore also takes shape as a form of peer-boundary work, in which the legitimacy of using AI is negotiated through everyday judgements about appropriateness. It can be argued that such norms help stabilise uncertainty in a rapidly changing technological environment. By anchoring evaluations of AI in ideas such as craft and authorship, journalists could be understood to articulate boundaries that preserve a sense of continuity in what journalism is understood to be, even as the material conditions of production are transformed. In this sense, resistance to AI could be reflected as an attempt to preserve particular understandings of professional legitimacy, where becoming a journalist is tied to undergoing the practical processes through which journalistic expertise is traditionally developed.

5.3.2 Learning AI Amid Ethical and Institutional Tensions

In addition to tensions surrounding the use of AI and normative ideas about appropriate journalistic practice, some respondents highlighted concerns related to the ethical dimensions of the AI industry and its broader societal implications. This tension can be understood as a friction between the practical need to engage with emerging technologies and a reluctance to fully legitimise the material and social conditions underpinning their development and use.

A theme that emerged from some respondents was the ethical implications of increasing dependence on external technological actors in journalistic work. Seen in relation to Puppis and Ali's (2023, p. 21) discussion of PSM legitimacy, these concerns point to questions of institutional autonomy, infrastructural dependence and the extent to which public service journalism should rely on systems developed and controlled by outside companies. This was particularly evident in how Sveriges Radio emphasised the importance of maintaining internal technological capacity:

> So Sveriges Radio wants to keep as much as possible in-house for several reasons. Both for preparedness reasons, since we have a civil preparedness mission, but also for data security and cost efficiency (...) independence has also become an important factor, for example. (R7)

This emphasis on internal development extends beyond editorial autonomy to include questions of infrastructural control. This shows a understanding of what journalistic independence requires in a digital environment, where the ability to operate independently from dominant technology providers becomes part of safeguarding public service values and institutional stability, as the strategist further explains:

> The advantage of Prompto is that it is based on an open-source solution, so we haven't built everything from scratch (...) but we do have control over the code. We wanted an AI tool where we could ensure that our data was handled correctly (...) that is the main rationale, to ensure redundancy and security. (R7)

This situates technological choices as questions of governance, where the ability to understand the systems being used becomes central to their legitimacy within the newsroom. At the same time, the AI strategist nuances the emphasis on security and control by pointing out that full internal ownership is not always practically feasible. This introduces a pragmatic recognition that organisational autonomy must be balanced against operational realities,

where reliance on external services can become necessary in order to maintain efficiency and resource management:

> But if there is a tool where a company delivers a service at a significantly better price, then there is always a trade-off between cost and efficiency. We have a responsibility to use our resources efficiently, because we can't simply reject all external collaborations, we cannot build everything we need ourselves, so we also have to purchase services. (R7)

Here, AI adoption can be understood as shaped by ongoing assessments of what forms of external collaboration are deemed acceptable within the boundaries of organisational sustainability. It can be argued that this illustrates how organisations seek legitimacy and stability by aligning with institutionalised expectations (Scott, 2014, p. 71), manifested here in how the institution positions itself within a media landscape that shapes its frameworks and modes of conduct.

This sense of necessary dependence was also reflected in how some respondents problematised the use of AI in relation to the importance of maintaining control through in-house development:

> Then you also know that if you use AI services other than those of Sveriges Radio, there is a certain political bias in the responses. But by developing our own tools, I think that helps avoid that. (R6)

What is at stake here is the concern of how journalistic organisations can rely on external systems without compromising their ability to critically assess the outputs they produce. This highlights how AI systems are seen as carrying embedded value assumptions that can influence the content they generate. As a result, technological choices also acquire a reflexive dimension, where the decision to use AI simultaneously becomes a question of which perspectives are allowed to shape journalistic work. Further, the respondent also complicates the idea of internally developed systems:

> Overall, it is not good to become too dependent on anything. I can also feel quite critical about us becoming dependent on the United States for our own developed tools. The United States may not be a country we can cooperate with in the long term, who knows? And I also think that development must not move too fast, because then I believe we will lose trust. (R6)

Even when opportunities for learning and training are available, the complexity of AI systems points to a broader concern about journalistic reliance on technologies whose underlying structures remain only partially visible. While previous research shows how PSM organisations often seek to implement AI through responsible, transparent and institutionally grounded processes, including guidelines, training and organisational value frameworks (Jones et al., 2022; Hilker et al., 2025), the findings suggest that such efforts do not necessarily remove the uncertainties journalists experience in practice. Even when implementation is clearly framed and supported, the underlying opacity of AI systems may still make it difficult for journalists to fully assess how outputs are produced and how they should be used. This becomes especially important because news organisations often depend on AI infrastructures and services provided by major technology companies, as the costs of computing power and specialised expertise make independent development difficult for many newsrooms (Simon, 2024). In this sense, the study supports more critical accounts of PSM's dependence on external AI infrastructures (Olsen et al., 2025; Simon, 2024). Despite efforts to strengthen autonomy through internal platforms and tools, PSM organisations remain embedded in a broader technological environment where full independence from externally developed systems is difficult to achieve. This also raises questions about how editorial autonomy is negotiated in a technological environment where key algorithmic processes and data practices may lie outside the full oversight of public service institutions. This concern is also echoed in one respondent's reflection on Sveriges Radio's position within the wider media landscape, where public service journalism is associated with particular demands for caution and responsibility:

> Sveriges Radio has to be somewhat cautious, and those of us who use it also have to be cautious, because we weigh our words in a very different way compared to perhaps commercial media. (R5)

Further, beyond questions of control, respondents also reflected on sustainability concerns and the broader implications of increasing AI adoption: "then there is also an environmental aspect" (R4). This refers to the perceived resource intensity of AI systems, particularly in terms of energy consumption and the broader environmental costs associated with the infrastructure required to train and operate them. This was connected to further considerations about whether the adoption of AI aligns with the perception that some respondents had on the societal responsibilities associated with PSM, where technological innovation is expected to be balanced against broader public and ethical concerns:

> There are also moral questions about things like the environment, and about the people who are put to work so that we can have AI at the level we have today. And that is where it can become a moral or ethical question that one perhaps should ask whether Sveriges Radio should contribute to or not. At the same time, maybe it can be compared to the fact that we all have phones? I don't know, but I personally hardly use AI at all in my private life because I don't think it's such a great thing, especially considering the environment and the people affected by it. (R5)

This can be interpreted as expressing a broader concern about the extent to which AI is becoming normalised within institutional practice. The respondent situates the technology within wider systems of production, where the consequences of technological development are perceived to extend beyond the newsroom itself. The comparison to smartphones further suggests an awareness of how difficult it can be to fully distance oneself from technologies that become deeply embedded in contemporary society, relating to the cultural-cognitive pillar where taken-for-granted beliefs and shared meaning systems shape how actors interpret what journalism is (Scott, 2014, pp. 66–70). This introduces a form of moral ambivalence, where respondents recognise that technological dependence may already be unavoidable in many aspects. At the same time, they question whether this should be taken as sufficient justification for further expanding the use of AI within journalistic institutions. From this perspective, hesitation toward AI is tied to uncertainty about where institutional boundaries of responsibility should be drawn.

Closely connected to this is the question of how AI is perceived to affect cultural and creative production, particularly in relation to what is perceived as the space for artistic expression and originality: "the way art is being suppressed" (R5). This was also raised regarding questions of copyright and intellectual property: "if I understand it correctly, Prompto is largely built on what we write, but you also don't really know whether it is copyrighted material" (R4). Once again, this points to an underlying uncertainty regarding how AI systems operate and what kinds of material they are trained on, where the technological processes behind the systems remain difficult to fully access or understand from the user's perspective. Even if the internal system is designed to minimise these risks by relying on material produced within Sveriges Radio, some respondents still expressed a degree of uncertainty: "even if it is supposed to be locked and protected, it does not really feel like you can fully trust it" (R5). Similar concerns were also expressed in relation to the use of external AI services that journalists themselves engage with in everyday work practices:

> I probably think about it every time I paste my script into, like Prompto, if there are any obvious errors from it, and then upload it to ChatGPT. Then it's Sveriges Radio's material that it can now train on. I feel uncertain about whether that is actually something good. At the same time, it will be published on the web later anyway. But yes, I feel a bit uncertain about it. (R6)

What becomes visible here is a heightened awareness of how journalistic material may circulate beyond the immediate editorial context once it is entered into AI systems. This introduces a tension between the practical convenience of using AI tools and the responsibility to protect editorial material and organisational integrity.

Here, questions about sustainability, labour conditions, copyright and data circulation all point toward a broader unease regarding the infrastructures that journalistic work increasingly becomes entangled with through AI use. At the same time, the material suggests that these concerns are rarely expressed as outright rejection of AI itself. Instead, respondents often articulate a more ambivalent position in which practical benefits coexist with uncertainty about the institutional and ethical boundaries of acceptable AI use. This ambivalence becomes particularly visible in relation to how functionality are weighed against concerns about organisational responsibility, control and long-term legitimacy.

Further, these reflections point toward a broader tension within the newsroom itself, where a shared emphasis on caution and responsibility does not necessarily translate into a unified understanding of how AI should be approached or integrated in practice. Even though a cautious approach is strongly emphasised at the managerial level and reflected in the importance placed on independence, redundancy and security, there are some differences in how AI is perceived within the organisation. In particular, attitudes among editorial staff and management do not always fully align, with AI from a management perspective sometimes being viewed more as one tool among others, as the strategist explains:

> I think AI technology in general will essentially become, like many other things, a normal part of our digital everyday life and working life, in the same way that, well, we may not be there yet, but AI will just be a natural part of your regular mobile experience or, as is already the case, many web browsers (...) I think it will become standard in the future. People won't think of it as AI, it will just be one technology among others to help you do what you want. (R7)

This reflects an understanding of AI, where the technology is framed as part of a gradually evolving set of non-disruptive tools embedded in everyday work practices. This view introduces a subtle tension with the more cautious or value-sensitive perspective. While questions of control and risk remain present, this framing shifts attention toward how AI becomes useful and gradually accepted as part of everyday work. This may suggest a future in which AI becomes less of a debated intervention and more of an unremarkable component of journalistic infrastructure. In such a development, journalists may experience AI as part of the routines and assumptions that structure newsroom work, reflecting how shared meanings become embedded within institutional practice (Scott, 2014, pp. 66–70). Building on this, the strategist further frames AI implementation as something that the organisation is, to some extent, compelled to engage with given the perceived opportunities the technology presents:

> But I think everyone sees the potential, and that is also why this technology is being talked about so much among journalists. We see that this represents enormous potential for better journalism, and whether or not that turns out to be the case, it is a technology that will affect our digital lives in various ways. Therefore, we need to understand it and use it. (R7)

This perspective subtly shifts the discussion toward the need of adaptation and preparedness. Thus, it can be argued that concerns are reframed within a broader emphasis on how journalism can remain capable and informed in a technological ecosystem that cannot be fully avoided. In this sense, the quote adds another layer, where caution coexists with a recognition that non-engagement itself may carry professional risks.

5.3.3 Organisational Enthusiasm vs. Editorial Scepticism

Lastly, the interviews also revealed tension between organisational ambitions surrounding AI implementation and the more hesitant perspectives expressed by some journalists. This tension unfold across different levels of analysis, from organisational narratives of innovation and efficiency, to editorial critiques of legitimacy and finally to individual experiences of professional adaptation and anxiety.

While AI was often framed from a managerial perspective as an inevitable technological development that journalism must adapt to, several respondents described a greater degree of scepticism toward some motivations behind its integration. In this sense, AI adoption was

reflected to be understood by broader organisational pressures to remain technologically up to date in a changing media environment:

> Oh, we have to do it otherwise we'll fall behind, and what drives this AI bubble is that everything is so speculative (…) so to say that this was, like, Sveriges Radio's brilliant idea is crazy, I think. Of course they've looked around and seen our competitors and things like that. (R4)

What becomes visible here is scepticism toward the narrative of innovation itself, where organisational engagement with AI is perceived as being driven partly by uncertainty and partly by imitation. In this sense, the respondent's perspective can be connected to the idea of institutional isomorphism (de-Lima-Santos et al., 2025, p. 2589), through which organisations gradually adopt similar structures and procedures in order to achieve legitimacy and stability within their institutional environment. This positions AI implementation as something shaped by institutional fear of falling behind, where legitimacy increasingly becomes tied to appearing technologically progressive.

When discussing why Sveriges Radio should engage with AI, management perspectives primarily framed the technology in terms of its perceived possibilities and future potential: "because there are great opportunities in the technology, just the simple answer" (R7). This is linked to the broader realm of innovation and technological progression, as the strategist explains:

> I would argue that innovation and efficiency are some of the core values at Sveriges Radio and in most media companies, actually (…) We have a framework governing how our resources may be used. Transparency, independence, and things like that form a framework that we operate within, and innovation also takes place within it (…) so I don't think it is a contradiction at all. (R7)

These statements position AI adoption within a framework where technological development is aligned with existing organisational ideals and the institutional ideoloy (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849). In this sense, AI is framed less as a disruptive challenge to journalism and more as a continuation of established institutional ambitions surrounding development and innovation. Further, it was explicitly communicated from a managerial perspective that the purpose of AI implementation is neither to replace human labor nor to function as a cost-saving strategy.

Rather, AI is percieved as one tool among many in the journalistic toolkit, intended to complement human expertise and enhance the overall quality of journalism:

> It is of course much cheaper to use AI voices, but I think the human voice is extremely important. I would also not want to use AI as a cost-cutting measure. Rather, it should be about us being able to level up and do more and better things. I don't want to lay off staff because I think an AI should write all the segments or anything like that. (R8)

In line with this, AI is presented as something employees are encouraged to experiment with in their own ways, reflecting the view that its value lies in how it can support and "level up" existing practices rather than replace them:

> At the newsroom, I want everyone to use AI in their everyday work. Then, I think people should figure out for themselves how they want to use AI. We work in different groups within the newsroom. (R8)

While this environment of openness and exploration was encouraged by all the respondents, several still questioned whether AI implementation can automatically be equated with innovation in itself. While the rationale behind AI adoption was to some extent understood and accepted, it nevertheless became subject to critical reflection:

> I can understand that it can be justified in terms of innovation, because it develops our work. But then, it probably also kills innovation among journalists, when you feed an AI with your own knowledge and creativity, tasks are taken away from you, and in that sense it's almost the opposite. (R5)

This suggests that what is presented as technological progress may simultaneously transform the conditions of creative practice through the gradual delegation of tasks to automated systems, thereby creating a paradox:

> It would have been great if we had been given, or worked together to develop, AI agents that actually suited our newsroom. Many of our current AI agents are quite rigid and clumsy, especially in terms of tone and writing style. At the same time, that is precisely why we are employed. That paradox is constantly present. (R5)

This is further reflected in another respondent's account, which also points to differing understandings of what counts as innovation and how PSM should define its role and responsibilities:

> I don't really think AI in itself is innovation. I mean, AI doesn't do anything that we can't do ourselves, it just does what we do, but in a sometimes much faster and more convenient way. So you can't just implement AI and say that you've achieved innovation. People might say, 'We are innovative because we use AI', but it's a bit like, everyone uses AI, so how the hell is that innovative? (R4)

Here, the respondents problematises the use of innovation as a label, suggesting that it can function more as a rhetorical justification for adoption than as a meaningful marker of change in journalistic practice. It also draws attention to the idea that AI largely reproduces tasks already within journalistic capability, suggesting that it does not necessarily amount to meaningful change in professional practice. Similarly, other respondents emphasise the importance of ensuring that AI is used in a deliberate and purpose-driven way rather than as an automatic or self-justifying addition to journalistic workflows:

> I think we could be better at allowing employees to use AI when there is actually a purpose for using it. You shouldn't use AI just for the sake of using AI. (R3)

This is further reflected in a respondent's appeal directed toward organisational leadership regarding future AI implementation:

> I wish to encourage all managers not to get too excited. Let us, the employees, get excited and see how we can use it. Don't push people, and don't think that now we can save a lot of money and avoid hiring people, that is my fundamental feeling about all of this. (R2)

Underlying these reflections were broader concerns about how AI might, over time, reshape the journalist's professional role. One respondent further developed this reflection by considering how AI implementation could influence the very grounds on which journalistic labour is justified:

> There is always an argument that, if your job can be done by an AI, then maybe there is no longer a justification for that role at all, but I don't think that applies to journalism as a whole. (R4)

Even if this rationalisation of AI is acknowledged, it still sits uneasily alongside understandings of journalism as grounded in its human dimension and the value attached to editorial judgement and practice. This is also reflected in a more speculative reflection on whether AI might eventually be capable of performing journalistic tasks at a higher level than humans, raising questions about the long-term implications of relying on such systems:

> The anxious part of me is kind of like, yeah, it starts that way but then, like, 'it can just as easily do everything' and that's kind of one reason why I don't want to do it, because I think the normalisation of it might not be great for our industry, or at least for employees in our industry in the long run. (R4)

These perspectives lead several respondents to describe a sense of urgency linked to the risk of falling behind in a rapidly evolving landscape if AI-related skills are not developed early on: "i think there is a fear that if you don't start learning it now, you can see that with future development you will fall even further behind" (R6). Further, it was also tied to more individualised ways of thinking about competence, where familiarity with AI is framed as a form of professional capital: "I think I can become an asset, so to speak, because I'm enthusiastic and know a lot" (R2). This also becomes visible within the newsroom culture for some respondents, where the surrounding social environment further reinforces the perceived need to keep up with developments in AI:

> I do notice that people are like, 'I'm going to become really good at AI so that I'll be needed or so I can have it on my CV', and so on, so that aspect is definitely there. (R5)

In this sense, expectations are further shaped by informal peer dynamics, in addition to organisational discourse. This concern is concretised in an internal sense of reflection on one's own professional competence, which for some respondents is experienced as something that can feel quite uncomfortable or difficult to confront:

> I can feel like, 'God, I should learn more,' but it's a bit of a resistance. I don't really want to, even if they are boring tasks, they are still my job duties, but yes, I can definitely feel that one should have a better grasp of it. (R5)

Similarly to this, even respondents who expressed strong reservations toward AI also described an awareness that increased engagement with the technology may become difficult to avoid over time:

> I just don't want to let go of the craft, I don't want to let go of the creative process. I'm also afraid that it could become a bit of a slippery slope. But the short answer is yes, I can absolutely imagine myself using it more. (R4)

What emerges here is how AI competence increasingly becomes tied to professional identity, where the ability to engage with new technologies is perceived as part of remaining relevant within the field. This can be understood as a tension between the normative and the

cultural-cognitive pillars (Scott, 2014, pp. 64–70). The cultural-cognitive pillar helps explain the taken-for-granted understanding of journalism as a human craft, where the creative process is seen as something that should remain grounded in the journalist's own judgement, voice and professional practice, rather than being handed over to AI. At the same time, the normative pillar highlights how changing expectations within the journalistic role may create pressure to engage with AI, as technological competence increasingly becomes associated with being adaptable and professionally relevant. The respondent's position therefore reflects a tension between preserving established understandings of journalistic work and adapting to emerging expectations surrounding AI use in the profession.

Overall, the material suggest that adaptation is mainly driven by a gradual sense that participation in AI-related developments may become professionally unavoidable. This creates tension in which resistance toward AI coexists with an awareness that refusing engagement may itself carry consequences for one's future role within journalism. What this also indicates is a shifting baseline for what is considered professional competence, where technological literacy is increasingly folded into expectations of journalistic work, as the strategist explains:

> What I can say is that journalists who do not learn to use this technology will not be as effective journalists. Someone said, 'AI will not replace journalists, but a journalist who uses AI will'. Like, it would be unthinkable for a journalist today not to use a computer and keyboard and instead only use pen and paper. (R7)

This quote consolidates a central thread running through the chapter; the gradual redefinition of journalistic competence in relation to technological mediation, where AI is positioned not as an external addition to professional practice but as something increasingly constitutive of it. In doing so, the strategist's framing positions adaptation itself as a normative benchmark for professional adequacy in journalism.

This shift in how legitimacy is articulated can also be translated into expectations around competence, as technological literacy is no longer framed as optional development but as part of maintaining professional adequacy within the field. Consequently, competence and learning are increasingly framed as conditions for journalists' ability to meaningfully operate within an evolving media environment. The computer and keyboard analogy presented above further reinforces this logic by framing AI adoption as a continuation of earlier processes through which new technologies became integrated into everyday work. In doing so, it

transforms what might otherwise be understood as a contested organisational choice into a taken-for-granted trajectory of professional evolution, where adaptation becomes a condition for continued participation rather than a matter of discretion. Taken together, this framing shifts the discussion from whether AI should be adopted in journalism to how quickly journalists are expected to align with it in order to remain professionally legitimate, suggesting that the space for opting out is increasingly narrowed rather than simply debated.

6. Conclusion and Discussion

This chapter brings together the study's central findings and situates them within broader theoretical, ethical and organisational discussions surrounding AI in journalism. Rather than treating AI integration as a straightforward process of technological adoption, the discussion highlights how its implementation at Sveriges Radio is shaped through ongoing negotiations around legitimacy, professional identity, public service responsibility and journalistic competence. The chapter further reflects on the study's limitations, discusses the implications of the findings in relation to the theoretical framework and previous research, and outlines possible directions for future research on AI in public service journalism.

6.1 Findings in Relation to Theory and Previous Research

The findings show that AI integration at Sveriges Radio can be understood as a process in which journalists negotiate the conditions under which AI is perceived as legitimate journalism and the point at which it is seen as threatening core journalistic values. Across the material, AI is accepted when it strengthens existing journalistic capacities, but becomes contested when it approaches authorship, judgement, creativity, trust or professional identity. This suggests that the significance of AI lies less in the technology itself and more in how it is interpreted through institutional norms, public service responsibilities and ideas about journalistic competence.

The first analytical claim is that AI tools are primarily integrated into journalistic workflows through routine and time-consuming tasks, while respondents also describe some changes in how work is distributed and carried out. The findings show that AI is currently used mainly to streamline routine and time-consuming tasks such as transcription, subtitling, translation, proofreading, summarising and research. This supports previous research showing how AI can automate routine tasks, reduce production time and streamline workflows (Calvo-Rubio & Rojas-Torrijos, 2024; Cools & Diakopoulos, 2024). At the same time, the findings extend this research by suggesting that AI may also expand journalistic practice by enabling new ways of working, particularly through large-scale analysis, content experimentation and forms of investigation that would otherwise be difficult to undertake within existing newsroom constraints. It also reflects the broader argument that generative AI has expanded across the news value chain (Pavlik, 2023, p. 85), since AI at Sveriges Radio is used across information gathering, material processing and editing rather than being confined to one

isolated part of production. The findings also nuance a purely efficiency-based understanding of AI. Respondents do not describe time savings as central to all AI uses, but where they do, saved time is often valued as it creates more space for editorial judgement, interpretation and decision-making. AI therefore becomes legitimate when it is understood as freeing journalists from repetitive work in order to strengthen, rather than weaken, core journalistic responsibilities. However, the findings further suggest that journalists describe changing work practices mainly as adjustments within existing journalistic workflows rather than as a fundamental transformation of journalism itself. Although some respondents perceived AI as expanding journalistic work, these changes were still understood as extensions of existing journalistic practice rather than as a replacement of its core principles. AI therefore appears to alter some of the practical conditions of daily work, while established professional values continue to guide how its role is evaluated.

The second analytical claim is that AI's legitimacy is conditional on preserving human responsibility. Respondents largely accept AI as assistance, but draw clear boundaries when it approaches authorship, editorial judgement, voice or accountability. Rather than suggesting that AI is simply reshaping journalism, the findings indicate that journalists' norms and perception of public service values condition how AI is adopted, interpreted and limited. This strongly supports the claim that new practices are evaluated through established rules, norms and shared meanings that define what is legitimate and appropriate (Scott, 2014, pp. 56–59). More specifically, the findings illustrate the normative pillar, since respondents define appropriate AI use through professional roles and obligations, particularly the journalist's responsibility to verify, interpret and stand behind published content. AI is sometimes rejected when it becomes problematic in weakening the journalist's role as an accountable author and evaluator.

Despite the rapid development of AI, the findings connects directly to previous research showing that journalists still remain cautious toward AI because of concerns about accuracy, poor editorial judgement, bias and loss of autonomy (Simon, 2024; Cools & Diakopoulos, 2024). However, the findings add nuance by showing that the boundary also concerns questions of human presence and communicative legitimacy. Respondents' scepticism toward fully AI-generated journalism shows that credibility is tied to the perception of the audience knowing that a human journalist remains responsible. This was particularly significant in a public service context according to the respondents. Theoretically, Puppis and Ali argue that

PSM legitimacy cannot rest only on efficiency, innovation or modernisation, but must be grounded in democratic responsibility and public value (Puppis & Ali, 2023, pp. 9–28). The findings reflect this, as respondents evaluate AI according to whether they believe it strengthens or risks weakening public trust. At the same time, the findings complicate the concept of PSM legitimacy and public value. Some journalists suggest that Sveriges Radio should be cautious precisely because it is not a commercial actor and should not adopt AI simply because others do. From a managerial perspective, however, AI is framed as something PSM should engage with because innovation and preparedness are part of remaining relevant. This creates tension between two understandings of legitimacy: one based on caution and trust, and another based on innovation and future capacity. Relating it to Fehlmann's view of legitimacy as perception (Fehlmann, 2023, p. 42), the findings shows that legitimacy is not perceived uniformly within the organisation. Rather, different actors interpret what makes AI legitimate in relation to different imagined audiences and organisational responsibilities. Journalists tend to anticipate audience reactions to AI in terms of trust and transparency, while managerial perspectives frame AI engagement as necessary for innovation and continued relevance. From the managerial level, AI integration is also presented as compatible with PSM values, since core journalistic methods are understood to remain unchanged and AI is positioned as another tool within the journalist's professional arsenal. Legitimacy is therefore not only a matter of external audience perception, but also an internal negotiation over what PSM should be seen to do in response to technological change.

The third analytical claim is that AI learning is becoming a contested part of journalistic competence. The findings support previous research highlighting journalists' concerns about insufficient AI literacy, particularly regarding limited understanding of how AI systems function, as well as the need for organisational guidance in AI implementation (Jones et al., 2022; Cools & Diakopoulos, 2024; Couraceiro et al., 2025). The respondents show that the key issue is not simply whether training exists. At Sveriges Radio, training initiatives were generally viewed positively, but also criticised for being too basic, too general and insufficiently connected to specific newsroom roles. This supports previous research showing that journalists often seek forms of AI literacy that go beyond technical instruction, placing greater emphasis on critical understanding and the ability to apply AI knowledge within journalistic practice (Couraceiro et al., 2025; Jones et al., 2022). Some respondents see clear uses for it, others struggle to see how AI is relevant to their specific role. This may suggest that AI's value is not built into the tool itself. Rather, it is shaped by interpretive flexibility

(Orlikowski, 1992, pp. 407, 408), where it becomes useful or problematic depending on the journalist's work tasks and newsroom context. Thus, when AI was perceived as useful and as contributing to either more effective or better journalism, it tended to be normalised as a legitimate and expected journalistic tool. In contrast, when journalists could not identify a relevant or reasonable application of AI within their own role, the technology was problematised to a greater extent.

However, the findings also show that, despite sceptical barriers to adoption, there was a sense among respondents that they may eventually need to engage with AI in order to remain professionally relevant. AI therefore remains open to interpretation while simultaneously creating pressure to engage with and adapt to it. As AI becomes embedded within broader organisational and newsroom expectations, it begins to reshape what is understood as journalistic competence, reflecting the organisational work and institutional ideology tied to journalists' professional identities (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849).

The pressure to engage with AI emerges both externally from a media landscape in which AI adoption is perceived as increasingly widespread, as well as organisationally through managerial framings of AI as necessary for innovation and relevance. This follows previous research of institutional isomorphism (Simon, 2024, pp. 11–13), where organisations may adapt in response to pressures from their wider field in order to maintain legitimacy. In this context, AI integration at Sveriges Radio can be understood as shaped by external expectations about technological development and internal efforts to position the organisation as innovative and aligned with the direction of the media industry. Pressure further appeared informally through newsroom cultures where colleagues' use of AI creates expectations to keep up. This pressure is internalised, as some journalists view AI learning as a way to improve their own practice and become better journalists. The pressure described here could potentially develop a regulative dimension in the future (Scott, 2014, pp. 59–64), particularly if AI competence becomes formally integrated into journalism education, professional training requirements or organisational policies that define what qualifications and skills journalists are expected to possess.

However, the findings suggest a less formal form of pressure. Respondents describe a sense that engaging with AI may become necessary to remain professionally relevant, rather than referring to explicit requirements or sanctions. This pressure is therefore better understood through the normative pillar, as AI use becomes connected to obligations and expectations of

appropriate journalistic behaviour (Scott, 2014, pp. 64–66). Thus, the pressure operates less through formal enforcement and more through changing norms and shared understandings of what it means to be a competent journalist. This supports Lischka's (2025) argument of how journalistic norms can shift as AI practices become increasingly accepted and institutionalised within the profession. The findings show a similar process at Sveriges Radio, where AI is gradually framed as compatible with journalistic competence when it is connected to established professional values rather than seen as a break from them. In this way, AI integration becomes part of an ongoing renegotiation of what counts as legitimate journalistic practice.

At the same time, the findings indicate that what constitutes journalistic competence in relation to AI implementation remains contested. Several respondents question whether AI use should automatically be understood as innovation. For them, AI may just as easily reduce creativity, weaken craft skills or become a symbolic marker of modernisation. This challenges the assumption that AI adoption is inherently innovative. Instead, the findings suggest that innovation becomes meaningful only when it contributes to journalistic value, not when it is adopted for its own sake. This can be discussed in relation to a strong vocational reflection (Raemy, 2021, pp. 844, 849), where professional journalistic identity is partly shaped by an individual commitment to the profession itself. In this context, considerable importance is placed on preserving journalism in its more traditional form, causing new technological tools to often be approached with scepticism.

Nevertheless, regardless of respondents' scepticism toward AI, its implementation can still be understood as disruptive in some ways. Respondents described AI as introducing new expectations around professional adaptation and changing work practices, even though its impact was not seen as extending to every aspect of journalistic work. Its disruption lies in how it changes the conditions around relevance and insecurity. In a fragile and competitive media landscape, AI is perceived to create new urgencies around competence. Journalists may resist AI on normative or ethical grounds, yet still feel pressure to learn it because not learning may carry professional consequences. This connects AI adoption to job insecurity in a subtle but important way. The concern instead centers on how journalists who fail to adapt may become less valued within a changing profession.

Taken together, the findings show that AI integration at Sveriges Radio develops through ongoing negotiations over how AI can be incorporated into journalistic work in ways that

align with professional values and public service responsibility. In relation to RQ1, AI can shape everyday workflows mainly by streamlining routine tasks such as transcription, translation, summarising, proofreading and research. These changes can alter the practical conditions of daily work by making some tasks faster, creating more space for editorial judgement and suggesting that AI may also expand journalistic practice by enabling new ways of working that would previously have been difficult to carry out within limited time and resources. However, they are described mainly as adjustments within existing journalistic workflows rather than as a fundamental transformation of journalism itself. AI becomes problematic when efficiency appears to be treated as an end in itself, rather than as a way to support journalistic quality and responsibility.

In relation to RQ2, journalists understand and negotiate the boundaries of AI use through concerns connected to authorship, editorial judgement, accountability, voice and trust. AI is largely legitimised when it supports existing professional standards, but becomes contested when it is perceived to weaken the journalist's role as an accountable author and evaluator. In this sense, the findings suggest that journalistic norms and public service values condition how AI is adopted, interpreted and limited.

Lastly, in response to RQ3, the findings show that AI creates both new educational needs and new tensions around professional competence. The main educational need concerns more situated and role-specific forms of AI literacy, where technical understanding is developed alongside professional judgement, everyday newsroom practices and clearer guidance on how AI can be meaningfully implemented within different journalistic roles. Further, AI produces tension in the adaptation, including concerns about external technological dependence and its ethical implications for institutional autonomy and public service responsibility. Journalists also feel that they may need to learn and engage with AI in order to remain professionally relevant, while also wanting to preserve the craft, creativity, judgement and their perception of values that they define public service journalism by.

6.2 Limitations and Areas for Development

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting the findings of this study. First, the study is based on a relatively small sample of participants. Although the interviews included journalists as well as individuals in managerial and strategic roles, the number of participants is limited to a single newsroom and a small group of professionals within the

organisation. Furthermore, due to the limited scope of the study, it did not include all professional groups involved in AI implementation, such as developers, legal experts or policy staff.

While the sample allowed for in-depth insights into participants' experiences and perspectives, it also means that the findings cannot capture the full diversity of views that may exist across other teams or departments within the organisation (Bryman et al., 2025, pp. 451). By focusing on a single newsroom, the case study design enables a detailed and contextually grounded understanding of organisational processes. At the same time, this focus limits the generalisability of the findings to other media organisations or contexts. As a result, the patterns identified in this study should primarily be understood as insights into how AI is experienced and implemented within this specific PSM context, rather than as findings that can be directly generalised to the broader media industry or to other PSM newsrooms.

Another limitation concerns the reliance on self-reported experiences gathered through interviews. The analysis is based on participants' own descriptions and interpretations of their practices and experiences with AI. While this provides valuable insight into journalists' perceptions, responses can be influenced by the way questions are formulated, as well as by participants' perceptions of the researcher, the study's purpose or their comfort level during the interview (Schwarz, 1999). Therefore, the data may not fully capture how AI is actually used in day-to-day newsroom practices, how it is experienced in practice or how effectively it has been implemented within the organisation.

Further limitations concern the rapid pace of technological change in the field of AI. As this study examines AI use in journalism within a rapidly evolving technological landscape, newsroom practices, tools and organisational strategies related to AI are continuously developing. As a result, policies and attitudes toward AI may change after the data collection period. The findings should therefore be interpreted as a snapshot of how AI was understood and implemented within the studied newsroom at a particular point in time, rather than as a fixed or final representation of these processes.

An additional consideration concerns the characteristics of the studied newsroom. The newsroom examined in this study operates within an organisational context where there is a stated ambition to remain at the forefront of innovation and technological development, as well as to continuously explore new tools and ways of working. This context may have

influenced how AI was discussed and adopted among participants, potentially creating conditions that are more receptive to technological change than in some other journalistic settings. Furthermore, several participants appeared to belong to professional cohorts with substantial experience of digital tools and platforms. Although this study did not examine whether there is a relationship between age and AI adoption, competencies, experiences and attitudes toward new technologies may vary across different professional groups. It is therefore possible that studies conducted in other newsroom contexts, characterised by different organisational cultures, professional backgrounds or demographic compositions, could produce somewhat different findings regarding the use and perception of AI.

Lastly, the study also does not include audience perspectives. This is significant because questions of PSM legitimacy and trust are central to the findings. The analysis shows how journalists and managers anticipate audience reactions to AI, both from their professional position as journalists and from their own experiences as news consumers. However, it cannot determine how audiences themselves perceive AI-assisted or AI-generated journalism.

6.3 Theoretical and Ethical Reflections

Theoretically, the study highlights the value of understanding AI integration as a sociotechnical process rather than as a purely technological development. AI does not enter the newsroom with a fixed meaning or predetermined effect. Its role is shaped through how journalists, managers and organisational structures interpret and apply it. At the same time, the study also suggests that interpretive flexibility has limits. Journalists may negotiate the meaning and value of AI, but these negotiations take place within broader pressures from the media industry, organisational strategies, newsroom culture and changing expectations of professional competence.

The study also points to the need to understand PSM legitimacy as internally contested. Legitimacy is often discussed in relation to how audiences perceive PSM, but this study suggests that legitimacy is also negotiated within the organisation itself. Different actors may attach different meanings to responsible innovation; for some, caution and restraint protect public trust, while for others, experimentation and preparedness are necessary for continued relevance. This means that AI does not only raise questions about what audiences will accept, but also about how PSM organisations define their own democratic role under conditions of technological change.

Ethically, the study raises questions about whether human oversight alone is sufficient as a safeguard for responsible AI use. While keeping journalists accountable for final decisions is essential, responsibility cannot be reduced to placing a human at the end of the production chain. At the same time, it may be unrealistic to expect journalists to gain an exact or complete understanding of how generative AI systems operate, particularly given their technical complexity, opacity and rapid development. The issue instead centers on the conditions journalists need in order to engage with AI critically in practice, including space to understand how the technology works, reflect on its limitations, and judge when its outputs can or cannot be trusted. Without this, human oversight risks becoming symbolic rather than substantive. This aligns with Cools and Diakopoulos (2024), who show that unclear AI guidelines can leave journalists uncertain about safe and responsible use, particularly when opaque systems may reproduce bias or discriminatory patterns.

AI literacy could therefore be understood as a form of critical and situated competence. In a PSM context, journalists need to understand AI well enough to ask the right questions. Whether the output is accurate, whether bias may be reproduced, whether sources and data handling are transparent and whether the use of AI can be justified in relation to editorial responsibility and public trust. This makes AI training part of the organisation's ethical infrastructure, because it can help journalists navigate uncertainty responsibly. Responsible AI use could therefore be argued to depend less on achieving complete technical understanding and more on developing the critical judgement needed to recognise when AI outputs should be questioned, limited or rejected. The ethical question instead concerns how AI use contributes to journalism's broader purpose; whether it supports democratic accountability, editorial responsibility and the public value journalism is meant to provide. In this sense, the ethical evaluation of AI must remain tied to the purpose of public service journalism rather than to technological possibility alone.

6.4 Conclusion and Future Research

This study has shown that AI integration in journalism should be understood as an ongoing negotiation rather than a finished technological transition. At Sveriges Radio, AI is already part of everyday journalistic work, but its role remains conditional on whether it is perceived to support editorial judgement, strengthen journalistic quality and remain compatible with PSM responsibility. Although AI is often portrayed as a transformative force in journalism, this study provides limited evidence that AI has fundamentally altered journalistic work at

Sveriges Radio. The study therefore shows how AI integration pushes journalism to reconsider what professional competence and responsible practice mean in a PSM context. Its significance lies in how PSM journalists make sense of AI within existing professional and institutional boundaries, deciding where the technology can support journalistic work and where its use must remain limited. At the same time, these boundaries do not remove the pressure to adapt. Even when journalistic norms and public service values condition how AI is adopted, journalists still describe a need to learn and develop more situated forms of AI literacy. This creates a central tension; journalists are expected to engage with AI in order to remain professionally relevant, while also protecting the craft, creativity, judgement and values through which they understand public service journalism as a profession.

Future research should continue to examine the effects of AI across different PSM contexts, particularly as these tools become more embedded in editorial routines, training structures and organisational strategies. Even within Sweden, perceptions of AI integration may vary between SR, SVT and UR, making it valuable to explore how different PSM organisations understand and adapt to AI in journalistic work. Longitudinal studies would be especially valuable for understanding whether current uncertainties become normalised practices, formalised rules or continued areas of resistance. At the same time, further research should not only be limited to PSM contexts. Comparative studies between PSM and commercial news media could clarify whether AI actually produces different organisational and ethical tensions across media systems, or whether similarities in journalistic method create more overlap than is often assumed. This perspective was particularly visible in the interview with the AI strategist:

> While it is clear that PSM may have a more extensive regulatory framework, as well as different opportunities and limitations compared to private media, I do not yet see any major differences in AI use. This is because the journalistic methods are the same at, for example, Aftonbladet and Sveriges Radio, if it is reduced to that level. (R7)

This suggests an important direction for examining how PSM differ in their mandates and accountability structures, while simultaneously exploring the similarities in AI use across different types of news organisations. Such research could help clarify whether the main differences lie in the tools themselves, the institutional conditions surrounding them or in how journalistic values are interpreted and defended across organisational contexts.

Lastly, future research could also focus more directly on audience perceptions. This study partly examines audience trust through journalists' understandings of accountability, but it does not investigate how audiences themselves perceive AI use in journalism. Further studies could therefore examine how audiences respond to current and potential future uses of AI and how these affect perceptions of trust and journalistic responsibility.

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